

Author's Note

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Chapter 1 – Embers and Echoes

Mami awoke to the soft golden light filtering in through the cabin windows, her breath rising gently in the cool morning air. For a moment, she simply lay there, letting the warmth of her blanket and the serenity of the space wrap around her like a familiar melody. No alarms. No urgent missions. Just peace.

She sat up slowly, stretching her arms above her head, and smiled. It was rare to wake up feeling rested—not just physically, but emotionally. Whatever dream she'd had was already gone, but it had left behind a feeling of quiet calm.

Outside, the forest was still misted with the soft veil of morning. Dew glistened on the leaves, and somewhere nearby, birds called to each other in sleepy rhythm.

She stepped out onto the wooden porch, brushing a hand through her hair. Kasumi was already out front, her bright orange hoodie tied loosely around her waist, one foot planted on a rock as she leaned into a stretch with surprising focus.

“Morning, Mami~!” Kasumi chirped without looking back. “Hope you didn’t oversleep. The sun’s already showing off!”

Mami chuckled softly. “Good morning, Kasumi. I slept well, thank you. And you?”

Kasumi grinned, now flipping into a side stretch with an exaggerated pose. “Dreamed I was a space pirate fighting ghost jellyfish with a flute. So, great night.”

Lunaria was nearby, moving through her own graceful routine—slow, deliberate stretches that looked almost like a form of meditation. She opened her eyes as Mami approached, inclining her head in greeting.

“Good morning, Mami. You look well.”

“I feel well,” Mami replied, taking a deep breath of the forest air. “It’s... peaceful here.”

They moved together, beginning a light round of stretches. Mami had seen Lunaria’s style before—almost like a dance—but it was the first time she saw **Kasumi** this focused on any sort of physical

discipline. She mimicked Kasumi's movements with mild curiosity, noticing that the silliness usually layered over Kasumi's actions had melted into something quiet and practiced.

"You're... surprisingly good at this," Mami remarked with a small smile.

Kasumi grinned sideways. "Gotta keep the adventuring performer's body in top shape! Flexibility, balance, strength—helps with flips, stage dives, and dramatic escapes."

Lunaria nodded faintly. "She may not always show it, but she's quite disciplined."

"Hey, don't ruin my rep," Kasumi winked. "I've got an image to uphold."

Laughter passed between them, warm and light. As they finished up and returned inside, the scent of herbs and warm grains filled the cabin. Breakfast was simple, nourishing, and shared in that easy, companionable silence they had all come to appreciate.

As they cleaned up, Lunaria turned to Mami.

"We're going to the arena after this," she said gently. "There's something we'd like you to see."

"The arena?" Mami raised an eyebrow. "Are we training again?"

Lunaria shook her head. "Not this time. We're watching."

Mami glanced between them, curious now. "Watching what?"

"You'll see," Kasumi said, waggling her eyebrows in mock suspense.

The three of them stepped outside once more, and with a gesture from Lunaria, the forest shimmered and warped. The air bent, colors shifting and deepening as the landscape twisted into something otherworldly.

The arena welcomed them once more—its smooth stone floor, its shifting skylight, the humming walls that echoed both past and present.

They took their seats in the flower observation pods, and as they settled in, Mami's curiosity grew. The air buzzed softly with magic.

Then, with a flash, a projection bloomed to life before them—hovering like a mirage above the arena floor.

The image sharpened into a familiar scene. A hospital. A boy on a bed. A girl with blue hair holding his hand.

Mami inhaled sharply.

"Sayaka..."

The projection played on.

The image sharpened into a familiar scene. A hospital courtyard. A boy sat outside in a wheelchair, a violin resting gently in his hands. Sunlight danced across the polished wood of the instrument. Around

him stood a small gathering—his parents, a nurse, and just behind them, a girl with bright blue hair, eyes shimmering with restrained joy.

Mami inhaled sharply.

“Sayaka...”

The boy—**Kyōsuke**—lifted the violin to his shoulder. His hands, once damaged and still marked by recovery, now moved with graceful precision. A bow slid across strings, and a soft, trembling note rang out.

The melody that followed wasn’t flawless—but it was alive. Raw. Hopeful.

Sayaka’s hands were clasped to her chest. She looked like she was holding her breath—like the world itself had gone still so it wouldn’t interrupt this moment. When Kyōsuke glanced her way mid-song and smiled, her entire face lit up.

“I’m so glad,” Sayaka whispered. “This was worth it. Even if it’s just once—I wanted to see him play again. And now he can. That’s all I need.”

Her voice was gentle but resolute. “I don’t regret anything.”

She turned to Madoka beside her and smiled like she had touched something divine.

Mami’s stomach turned.

It should have been beautiful.

But all she could feel was horror.

She clenched her hands in her lap, her breath catching in her throat.

Not her, Mami thought. Not Sayaka.

Not again.

Lunaria’s words from that first night echoed in her mind—about the truth behind wishes, about the hidden cost no one told you until it was too late. About the Soul Gems. The despair. The decay.

And Sayaka had walked into it smiling.

Mami’s heart ached. She remembered that same look in her own eyes once—back when she thought she’d made a noble choice. A selfless wish. A beautiful sacrifice.

But now she knew what it really was.

A trap.

“She doesn’t understand...” Mami whispered, almost involuntarily. “She doesn’t know what she’s given up.”

Sayaka's joy was real—radiant, even. But it was a candle burning against a storm.

Mami had lived it. The fading light. The growing darkness. The slow, silent unraveling of everything you thought made you human.

She felt sick.

“She thinks this is love,” Mami whispered, barely audible. “She doesn’t know how much it will hurt.”

Beside her, neither Kasumi nor Lunaria said a word. But Mami could sense their presence—quiet, grounded, and supportive, as if they knew she needed space to feel this fully.

Sayaka smiled at Kyōsuke as he played, never suspecting the truth—that her Soul Gem had already begun to cloud. That her story, so full of hope in this moment, had already started writing its tragedy.

Mami sat frozen, her heart torn between the image of the girl she once mentored—and the painful knowledge of where that path would lead.

And she could do nothing to stop it.

The image shifted.

A new figure appeared.

Crimson hair. Black boots. A familiar, swaggering walk.

“Kyouko...” Mami breathed, sitting up straighter in her seat.

In the projection, Kyoko surveyed the area Mami once watched over. Her smirk didn’t reach her eyes.

“So... some fresh little idiot took your place, huh?” Kyoko muttered, biting into an apple as she slouched on a railing overlooking the city. “Guess I should give her a proper welcome.”

Her tone was flippant. Cold. But the gleam in her eyes was unmistakable—anger. Or maybe something deeper.

Mami’s heart twisted.

They hadn’t parted well.

After Kyoko’s family...

After the grief turned to bitterness...

After Kyoko’s faith was broken by her own wish...

They had become strangers. Worse—opposites.

There was a time when Kyoko would have said something like, “*We protect people, no matter what.*” She had been stubborn, yes, but idealistic. Fiercely kind. That was the Kyoko Mami had trusted at her side, the girl who used to grin through battles and talk about saving the whole city someday.

But after her family...

Mami closed her eyes for a moment.

She remembered the day Kyoko stopped smiling. The day the fire in her went from warm to consuming. She remembered the final fight—the shouting, the accusations. The heartbreak of watching someone you cared about turn away from everything you believed in.

Kyoko had learned the cost of a wish in the cruelest way possible—and it had twisted her. Hardened her. She survived by refusing to care.

And now, she was going to meet Sayaka.

A girl so much like Kyoko once was.

Mami looked back at the projection. Sayaka was still glowing with that innocent certainty—that belief that doing good was all that mattered. That love, sacrifice, and courage were enough.

But Mami knew better now.

Sayaka was about to be tested in the same cruel crucible.

And Mami couldn't stop it.

Her hand clenched tightly around the edge of her seat.

"Sayaka..." she whispered. "You don't know what's coming."

She saw it like a mirror reflecting the past.

Sayaka would try to hold onto her ideals, just like Kyoko had. She would burn herself out trying to protect people who wouldn't understand her sacrifice. She'd love too deeply. Give too much. And when the world didn't love her back in the way she hoped—

She would break.

Just like Kyoko did.

Just like *she* did.

Mami's throat felt tight.

"I should have been there for you," she murmured. "For both of you..."

She remembered Kyoko's rage when they fought. But beneath that rage had been pain—raw, unbearable grief that had nowhere to go. Kyoko never truly hated her. She was just lost. Alone.

And now Sayaka was walking into that same storm.

Would Kyoko see the reflection of her old self in Sayaka?

Would she try to push her away, the same way she pushed Mami?

Or... would something change?

Mami didn't know.

But she feared what would happen if it didn't.

She couldn't protect them from this world anymore—not Sayaka, not Kyoko. All she could do now was watch, her heart aching, as the projection played on... and history threatened to repeat itself.

The next projection showed Sayaka and Madoka tracking a witch's familiar. Sayaka lunged—blade ready—but a flash of red knocked her aside.

Kyoko.

The two girls faced each other. Tension crackled like fire between them.

"You're wasting energy," Kyoko said coolly. "Let it eat a few more people. When it turns into a full witch, *then* we strike. It's called efficiency."

Sayaka recoiled. "That's—monstrous! We're supposed to protect people!"

Kyoko rolled her eyes, but Mami could see the hurt buried deep behind the mask.

And then they clashed.

Blades against spears.

Past against present.

Hope against cynicism.

Mami stared, transfixed—and horrified. This wasn't just a fight between two magical girls.

It was a reflection.

Of what happens when they're forced to walk the path alone.

The scene shifted.

The sky above the city burned gold with the late afternoon sun as Sayaka faced down Kyoko in an empty plaza. Madoka stood off to the side, visibly distressed, hands clasped near her chest.

Sayaka, ever defiant, raised her sword. "If you think I'm going to let you hurt people just so you can harvest grief seeds—forget it!"

Kyoko grinned, spinning her spear with a flash of red light. "You're all heart and no brain, huh? Let's see how far that gets you."

The clash was immediate—steel on steel, sparks flying, magic crackling through the air.

Sayaka fought with everything she had. But it wasn't enough.

Not against Kyoko.

The older girl's movements were ruthless, fluid, unrelenting. She broke through Sayaka's guard over and over again, slamming her backwards with every blow. Sayaka staggered, panting, her blade trembling in her grip.

Mami flinched.

"Stop... Sayaka, you're not ready..."

But the girl in blue couldn't hear her. Couldn't know what waited down this path.

Then—

A brutal kick. Sayaka went flying, crashing into a pillar with a sickening thud.

Madoka gasped. "Sayaka!"

She took a step forward—eyes wide, lips trembling—before suddenly gripping her pendant. She stared at it.

"If I make a wish," she whispered, "I can stop this. I can help her."

Mami's breath caught.

"No—Madoka, don't."

Her voice echoed uselessly through the arena.

Madoka's eyes filled with resolve. "I could wish for the fighting to stop. I could—!"

Mami shook her head violently. "You don't understand. That's exactly what *they* want."

Her hands trembled in her lap. Watching Sayaka fall apart was unbearable—but watching Madoka hover on the brink of making the same mistake was worse. She saw it in her eyes: the desperation. The willingness to sacrifice herself without knowing the price.

The truth that Lunaria had shown her—the truth about the system, about Soul Gems, about despair—it burned in her chest.

"I have to stop this," Mami whispered. "I have to—"

But she was just a spectator now.

And then, just as Kyoko raised her spear for a finishing strike—

Time fractured.

A pulse like a heartbeat, and the air distorted with sudden static.

Everyone froze.

And there she was.

Homura.

She appeared between them like a shadow pulled from the falling light, hand outstretched, time magic still humming at her fingertips. Sayaka barely blinked before her knees gave out.

She collapsed.

Unconscious.

Kyoko stepped back, startled. “What the hell?!”

Homura turned her head only slightly.

“I won’t let you destroy each other,” she said coldly. “Not today.”

Sayaka lay still on the pavement. Kyoko’s expression hardened.

“Why’d you knock her out? She wasn’t even—”

“She would have died,” Homura said flatly.

Madoka ran forward. “You didn’t have to hurt her!”

Homura didn’t respond.

Instead, she turned toward Kyoko.

“Walpurgisnacht is coming. Two weeks.”

Kyoko’s eyes narrowed. “...You serious?”

Homura nodded once. “You know what it can do.”

There was a long pause.

Then Kyoko clicked her tongue and shrugged. “Fine. I’ll help you. If that storm’s coming, I’m not dying alone.”

Mami’s eyes widened. *Walpurgisnacht...*

She had only heard the name in whispers—one of the strongest Witches in existence. It made sense now. Why Homura was always watching. Always warning. But how did she know? And her methods...

Madoka stepped in front of her unconscious friend, arms spread protectively.

As Madoka knelt beside Sayaka, eyes wide with fear and guilt, Homura stood over them like a shadow cast from a far colder world.

“She made her choice,” Homura said flatly. “There’s nothing you can do now. Sayaka is already too far gone.”

Madoka looked up at her, shocked.

“You don’t know that!”

Homura's gaze hardened. "I *do*."

Then, her voice dropped—still emotionless, but edged with something sharper, more desperate beneath the surface.

"Madoka. Don't make a wish. Ever. Not for Sayaka. Not for anyone. She is beyond saving. Don't throw your life away for someone who won't come back."

That was the final line.

The one that snapped whatever was holding Madoka back.

"You're awful," she said, voice trembling. "You always act like you don't care. You just treat Sayaka like she's a lost cause!"

Homura didn't turn around.

"You keep telling me to give up on her! But I won't! I won't give up on Sayaka!"

Silence.

Then, slowly, with her back still turned, **Homura's fingers curled.**

Mami saw it.

That small, tight motion. Not anger.

Pain.

Just like that time...

The time Homura found Mami's body, too late to help. The same grimace, the same flicker of something buried deep beneath the cold. A flicker Mami now recognized for what it was:

Grief.

She was breaking. But only for a moment.

And then, the mask returned.

"Do what you want," Homura said, her voice ice again. "But don't come crying to me when she falls."

She walked away, shadows swallowing her steps.

Mami sat frozen in her seat.

Her mind reeled from everything—Sayaka broken, Madoka fraying, Homura cracking beneath the pressure of knowing too much.

It wasn't just about fighting Witches anymore.

This was a tragedy unfolding in slow motion.

And she couldn't do a single thing to stop it.

Chapter 2: The nature of life

The projection dimmed, fading into a haze of lingering light. The arena returned to silence—its towering walls echoing nothing but the soft hum of residual magic.

Mami sat still in her pod, hands clenched tightly in her lap. Her breathing was steady—but only because she was forcing it to be.

Everything inside her felt like it was spinning.

Sayaka. Kyoko. Homura. Madoka.

Everything she thought she'd left behind—everything she thought she'd made peace with—had just unfolded in front of her like a wound torn open.

She stood up slowly, her legs moving before her mind could catch up. The hush between the three of them stretched thin.

And then—

“I should have seen it coming,” Mami said quietly, her voice cracking just slightly. “Sayaka... she always wore her heart on her sleeve. She never hesitated to throw herself into someone else’s pain.”

She turned toward Kasumi and Lunaria, both watching her with quiet patience.

“I told myself she’d be safe. That she wouldn’t make a wish like I did. That maybe she’d see through it, or maybe Madoka would stop her. But...”

Her fists trembled at her sides.

“She made the wish anyway. For someone else’s dream.”

Mami’s eyes glistened with unshed tears as she looked toward the now-empty space where the projection had been.

“She doesn’t even know what she’s given up. What’s waiting for her when that hope starts to crack. And Kyoko—”

Her voice broke for a moment, then returned lower, steadier.

“She used to fight by my side. She believed in protecting people. Until she lost everything. After her family... she changed. Hardened herself. Shut the world out. And now... now she’s just circling Sayaka like a vulture.”

She pressed a hand to her chest, taking a shaky breath.

“They’re both on a path I know too well. Idealism giving way to despair. Loneliness wrapped in stubborn pride. And Madoka...”

Mami’s gaze dropped to the floor.

“She almost made a wish. Just to stop a fight. Just to save someone she loves. I saw myself in her. Too much. That kind of kindness... it gets twisted. It gets eaten alive.”

She turned toward Lunaria now, her eyes wide—not with fear, but with rawness. Honesty.

“I thought I was ready to see the world again. But I wasn’t ready for *that*. For how much it still hurts.”

Silence hung between them.

Then Mami looked away, wiping the corner of her eye with the back of her hand.

“...I don’t want them to end up like me.”

Mami sat back slowly in the pod, the last flickers of the projection still echoing in her mind. Her thoughts weren’t only with Sayaka, or Kyoko, or Madoka.

They were with *Homura*.

That tiny moment— a fraction of second—when Madoka shouted at her, and Homura’s fingers curled, her back stiffening. Mami had seen that before. That same fleeting grimace. That crack in the mask.

It was just like the first time she saw Homura on the recordings, arriving too late to stop Charlotte. She’d hidden it then, too—only for a breath—but the pain had been there. Not anger. *Grief*.

“She hides it so well...” Mami murmured aloud.

Kasumi and Lunaria looked over, listening in silence.

“She’s *trying* to seem heartless,” Mami continued, still processing it aloud, “but I saw it again. She’s *hurting*. She acts like she’s given up on Sayaka... but I don’t think she has. She’s just—she’s protecting herself. From more loss.”

Her gaze dropped, troubled.

“And how does she know about the timing of Walpurgisnacht?” she whispered. “It’s not the kind of thing a magical girl just stumbles upon... It’s like she’s seen it before.”

Her brows furrowed as the implication lingered in the air.

After a long pause, Mami looked up at them—really looked—and her voice cracked with earnestness.

“Please,” she said, standing. “You helped me. You *saved* me. You saw that I was on the edge and didn’t let me fall. Please... do the same for them.”

She took a shaky step forward, hand pressed to her heart. “They don’t know yet. They don’t understand what this all means. But they’re *good girls*. They’re brave. They care about each other. I know what it’s like to be where they are. Just a little push... just one kind voice at the right time—it could change everything.”

Lunaria didn’t speak immediately.

Her expression was calm, but there was a weight behind her violet eyes. A quiet sorrow.

When she finally answered, her voice was soft. “We will not intervene. Not yet.”

Mami’s face twisted. “*What?*”

“They are not ready,” Lunaria said, still serene but with a distant sadness in her voice.

Mami’s voice rose, disbelief painting every word. “How can you say that?! You *helped me!* You *taught me!* Why are they any different?!”

Kasumi leaned back in her chair, arms crossed, not smug—but grounded. Measured.

“What’s the point of helping them now?” she asked, not cruelly, but bluntly.

Mami’s mouth opened—but she couldn’t speak yet.

Kasumi went on. “Sayaka still thinks wishes are pure. That trading your soul is just a small price to pay. She’s fighting for someone else’s dream like it’ll save her.”

“She’s *innocent*,” Mami argued, voice raw. “Doesn’t that mean we should help her before—before she breaks?”

Kasumi didn’t flinch. “And what would she do with that help? Listen politely? Say thank you? And keep on walking toward the same fate, because she still believes she’s right?”

Mami hesitated, breath catching in her throat.

Kasumi’s voice softened slightly. “Kyoko... she’s been through more than Sayaka. She *knows* loss. But even now, she’s stuck in survival mode. Hoarding grief seeds. Living for herself. She thinks the only way to win is to *stop caring*.”

She looked down into her hands, her tone thoughtful. “And Madoka... she’s the kindest of them all. But that kindness makes her fragile. She was about to throw away her soul just to stop a *single fight*. Can you imagine what Kyubey would do with a heart like that?”

Mami’s jaw clenched. “So what, we let them suffer? We just... watch them fall?”

Kasumi looked at her—serious now, all theatrics gone. “You want to help them. I get that. But you didn’t get here because we handed you answers. We didn’t protect you from the truth.”

Mami looked to Lunaria, searching, hoping—but Lunaria’s expression remained unchanged. Calm. Compassionate. Unyielding.

“We *threw you into the deep end*,” Kasumi said gently, “because we knew you had to face it yourself. The truth about wishes. About despair. About becoming a witch.”

Lunaria finally stepped forward, her presence quiet but grounding. “You understand now, Mami. Not because we spared you the pain—but because you felt it. Survived it. And *grew* from it.”

Mami’s breath slowed.

“They have to reach that point too,” Lunaria continued. “Their own moment. Their own breaking point. Not because we wish it upon them... but because life doesn’t stop for magical girls. And the only way forward is through understanding. Not just being *told*. But knowing in their bones what it all means.”

Kasumi nodded slowly, arms still folded, but her tone softened as she spoke next.

“Actions have consequences, Mami,” she said. “Especially when those actions are supernatural. Making a wish with Kyubey—it’s not just a choice. It’s a contract. A *permanent* one.”

She leaned forward slightly, voice firmer. “You don’t get to hit ‘undo’ when things start going bad. You don’t get a reset button just because you *meant well*. Life doesn’t work that way. And it *shouldn’t*.”

Her eyes met Mami’s with uncharacteristic clarity. “If you make a choice that changes your fate, then you have to face what comes next head on. You have to *own it*. That’s part of growing up. That’s part of being a magical girl.”

Mami stared back, silent.

Kasumi’s next words came with a weight Mami didn’t expect.

“No one’s coming to save you just because the path you picked got dark. That’s not kindness. That’s avoidance. And you *know* what that avoidance costs in this world.”

She sat back, her expression a little sad now. “We help those who are *ready* to be helped. Who understand the stakes. Who don’t just want to be rescued, but want to *change*.”

There was a long pause.

Then Kasumi smiled faintly—soft, not unkind. “You were ready, Mami. That’s why we stepped in.”

The room fell silent.

And for a moment, the arean’s quiet felt almost sacred.

Mami stood there, her fists trembling. Her heart ached with helplessness. With anger. But behind it... she couldn’t deny the truth of their words.

She thought of her first encounter with them—how she’d fought, cried, broken down.

They hadn’t coddled her. They *challenged* her.

And now...

She could finally see *why*.

She sank slowly back into her seat, eyes unfocused as she stared into the void.

The silence was no longer cold. It was heavy. Reflective.

And Mami, for the first time in that long, quiet moment, said nothing at all.

Mami let out a slow breath, finally breaking the silence. Her shoulders eased, just slightly, as she glanced toward Kasumi.

“You know,” she said, voice a touch lighter, “I don’t think I’ve ever seen you so serious before.”

Kasumi immediately perked up, a mock gasp of offense leaping to her face. “Ugh! Don’t remind me. That was practically a monologue!” She stood up, brushing imaginary dust dramatically from her sleeves. “You’ve ruined my whole brand, Mami Tomoe. Now I’ll have to start charging you for the **emotional damage.**”

Mami couldn’t help it—she laughed. Really laughed. The tension didn’t vanish entirely, but it cracked, letting in something warmer.

Lunaria smiled softly at the exchange, then turned to Mami with a small, graceful nod. “Thank you. For hearing us out.”

Mami gave a faint nod of her own.

Lunaria then tilted her head. “Would you like to begin something new in your training? Now that you carry this understanding with you.”

Mami hesitated, her brows furrowing—not from doubt, but thoughtfulness.

Mami hesitated, her brows furrowing—not from doubt, but thoughtfulness.

“...I think the truth will come for them eventually,” she said quietly. “Maybe not all at once, but when one of them becomes a witch—or watches it happen to someone they care about... it’ll hit. Just like it hit me.”

Her voice was steady, but the weight behind her words was unmistakable.

“When that moment comes... I want to be able to help them. Not just stand there helpless, or too late. I want to be ready.”

She looked to Lunaria now, resolve settling in her eyes. “Yesterday, I started learning how to face negative emotions directly—how to endure them instead of run from them. But now...”

Her hands clenched slightly in her lap.

“...I want to start learning dis-connect, if I can. I want to be able to do something when the time is right.”

There was a beat of silence.

Then, both Kasumi and Lunaria smiled.

“That’s the answer I was hoping for,” Kasumi said brightly, hands on her hips. “Not begging someone to swoop in and save the day. Not waiting for a miracle. Just you—choosing to be ready. That’s the real start.”

Mami gave her a small, grateful smile.

Lunaria nodded softly, folding her hands in front of her. Her tone remained calm, but there was a gravity to her words now.

“Dis-connect is an advanced technique, Mami,” she said. “It allows the user to siphon another person’s magical energy—extracting it, redirecting it, even nullifying it in certain cases.”

Mami’s eyes widened slightly. The implications of that kind of power hit her instantly. To take another magical girl’s energy... to drain it? It sounded dangerous. Very broken. But Lunaria continued before she could speak.

“That level of dis-connect requires immense discipline, control, and emotional clarity. It’s not something you can rush into, and not something to use lightly. It changes the flow of power. Of consequences.”

Mami’s brows drew together. Her fists tightened again, but this time it wasn’t from frustration—it was from focus.

“But,” Lunaria added, “what you’re describing—that desire to support others when they reach the edge—it’s possible to train a portion of the technique. A lesser form of dis-connect, which allows you to siphon only negativity from another person’s soul gem.”

Mami blinked, her breath catching for a moment.

“Siphon... only the darkness? You mean what you did to me, when I was about to break, right?”

Lunaria nodded. “Correct. In that moment, I disconnected your negativity from your soul. You can learn to do the same. The negativity you draw in can then be used to augment your own power. But that requires delicate control—not just over your own emotions, but over the flow of another’s magic and despair. That level of mastery takes time.”

Mami swallowed, the weight of the idea settling over her. To share in someone else’s pain—intentionally—and not falter. It frightened her. Could she learn it in time?

Lunaria, watching her closely, continued, “However, if your goal is simply to keep someone from falling... there’s an even simpler form. You can release the negativity into the universe as raw energy. You won’t gain strength from it—but you’ll lighten their burden. And that version bypasses the deeper magical entanglements.”

Mami’s eyes brightened. Hope flickered in her chest like a small, steady flame.

“That lesser technique... that’s exactly what I want,” she said. “If I can just do that—then maybe I can be there when they need it most.”

Lunaria gave a small nod, her smile faint but warm. “Then we’ll begin. With the fundamentals. No shortcuts. Step by step.”

Kasumi gave an exaggerated sigh and wiped away an imaginary tear. “There it is. That was the most responsible thing anyone’s said all day. Our little golden veteran is growing up.”

Mami laughed—genuinely this time—and shot Kasumi a playful glare. “You’re the last person who should be saying that.”

Kasumi winked. “Probably. But I stand by it.”

Lunaria stepped forward, the faint shimmer of magical energy beginning to stir in the air around her. “Let’s go to the grove. We’ll start with the foundations of *connect*. Once that’s solid, we’ll move into the lesser *dis-connect* training.”

Mami inhaled deeply, the scent of pine and morning dew grounding her.

Then she gave a firm, steady nod.

“I’m ready.”

Chapter 3: A Step Forward

In a ripple of light, the world shifted once more.

The three girls reappeared in the heart of the grove—a place that seemed to hum with life itself. Sunlight streamed through the trees in gentle shafts, dappling the mossy earth with gold. Birds called from the canopy, their songs echoing like flutes in the quiet morning air. The scent of wildflowers, earth, and wind filled the grove, carried on a gentle breeze that stirred the leaves overhead.

Mami took in a slow breath, grounding herself in the moment. The calm, vibrant beauty of this place always struck her—an oasis untouched by despair.

Kasumi stretched dramatically, arms high above her head with a theatrical yawn. “Ah~ What a lovely day to stir up some trouble in the name of peace.”

She turned to the others, grin wide. “Seems like we’ve got two interesting fronts now. One: the ever-growing rumors in Kamihama. And two: our tragic little drama unfolding with Madoka and her crew.”

Lunaria nodded. “Both are worth watching.”

“Exactly. So, I propose a split.” Kasumi gestured with a flourish. “I’ll go sniff around Kamihama—see what the rumor mill’s churning out and make some new friends. Lunaria, you keep tabs on the other girls while giving Mami the magical bootcamp she deserves.”

Lunaria didn’t hesitate. “Agreed.”

Mami turned toward Kasumi. “And... what exactly are you going to do out there?”

Kasumi grinned like she'd been waiting for that question. "Oh, you know. A little adventuring. A little mingling. Maybe crash a few tea parties, or save a damsel or two. Build some connections, gather information. All that good stuff."

She spun once on her heel, her cloak flaring behind her. "Besides, I've made it this far wandering. Kamihama's just another stop on the road—who knows what kind of fun's waiting?"

She gave an elegant bow. "Do wish me luck, dear ladies."

With a twinkle of bells and a flash of light, she vanished from the grove.

Mami smiled to herself, watching the space where Kasumi had stood. "She's... really something."

"She is," Lunaria agreed, her tone soft. "Even in the face of uncertainty, she carries hope. There's strength in that."

She turned to Mami and extended a hand, her expression calm and focused. "Come. Let's begin."

They stepped forward into the forest, the sounds of birdsong echoing around them as the trees closed gently behind.

Training waited.

And this time, Mami was ready for it.

Chapter 3a: Stillness in the Grove

Lunaria led Mami deeper into the forest, their footsteps soft on the moss-covered path. The air was cool and fragrant with the scent of leaves, distant blooms, and something older—earthy, ancient, and alive. Shafts of sunlight streamed down in golden beams through the canopy, dancing along their shoulders as they walked.

They emerged into a wide, open glade. The clearing was encircled by tall trees whose branches wove together above like a protective dome. Wildflowers swayed gently in the breeze, and a quiet stream trickled along the edge of the grove, its water catching the light like scattered gemstones.

Mami instinctively slowed her steps, letting the serenity settle over her. It wasn't just beautiful—it was peaceful. Purposeful. A place that seemed made for reflection. Or healing.

Lunaria paused at the center and gestured around them. "This is where we'll begin," she said softly. "It's a quiet place—meant for grounding. You'll practice the fundamentals of Connect here. Starting with meditation."

Mami gave a small nod, her gaze still sweeping the area. "This place feels... different. Like it's waiting for something."

Lunaria looked pleased. "It is. It's waiting for stillness. Connection can't begin until you know how to listen—to yourself, and to the world around you."

Mami knelt down, settling into the grass, and took a deep breath. She glanced at Lunaria. “I remember the theory,” she said. “Connect is what lets magical girls sync their magic, right? In a fight, it allows you to boost your power, share abilities, or even launch tag-team attacks. It’s... how you stand a chance against powerful witches.”

Her voice quieted slightly. “But... I’ve only ever heard about it. I never got to use it. I always fought alone.”

Lunaria’s gaze softened. “A basic understanding helps,” she said, sitting down across from Mami with effortless grace. “But Connect isn’t only between magical girls. That’s only one form.”

She picked up a small flower beside her and held it gently. “Kasumi and I, for example... We connect with nature. With animals, plants, even water and soil. When we gather ingredients, we don’t just take—we ask. We attune ourselves to the world and listen for what it’s willing to give.”

She placed the flower back unharmed. “That essence—that exchange—is a kind of magic. A kind of Connect.”

“I hadn’t... even considered that. Even after you said you use the ‘essence’ of nature, I still thought your ingredients were just... conjured, or summoned, by some advanced technique. I never would’ve guessed it was Connect.”

Lunaria gave a small nod, her expression pleased. “Most assume that. It’s not their fault—‘essence’ can sound vague until you experience it for yourself. But Kasumi and I don’t just pull things out of thin air. We attune. We align. That is the core of Connect—bringing yourself into resonance with another energy, whether it’s a person... or the world around you.”

“There are many styles. Many ways to apply the same truth. You saw it in our fighting: Kasumi, all passion and fire. Me—stillness and control. Two expressions of the same intent.”

Mami was quiet for a moment, eyes thoughtful. “So even that... is part of the same technique.”

Lunaria nodded. “Exactly. The more you learn, the more you’ll see it: knowledge isn’t isolated. It spirals outward. What seems separate—combat, cooking, healing, even magic—can all connect—pun intended,” she added with a faint, teasing smile, “in ways you’d never expect.”

Mami looked down at her hands in her lap, then slowly closed her eyes.

“All knowledge... connects,” she murmured, testing the words. The idea settled deep in her chest, like something she’d always known but never had the words for.

Lunaria’s voice drifted gently through the quiet grove. “Good. Then we begin now. Focus on your breath. Feel the energy around you. The trees. The wind. The ground beneath you.”

And so Mami did.

For the first time in her life, she wasn’t rushing toward battle. She wasn’t bracing for loss.

She was learning to listen.
To still herself.
To open.
To connect.

Mami sat down in the soft grass, settling into a relaxed position. The grove was quiet, save for the distant murmur of leaves and the chirps of unseen birds. The sunlight filtered through the canopy in golden beams, dancing gently on the earth. Lunaria sat beside her without a word, folding into stillness with the kind of grace that made it look effortless.

Mami closed her eyes.

At first, there was only her breath. In and out. Slow. Measured. The rise and fall of her chest, the gentle thrum of her heartbeat. But as she focused, something began to shift. Her awareness, at first turned inward, started to stretch outward.

The world wasn't silent at all.

She could sense life now—the tiny scurry of insects beneath the soil, the rustle of fur as small animals moved through the underbrush, the chatter of birds far above. The soft sway of plants moving with the breeze, not randomly, but like they were breathing with her. Everything pulsed with energy, alive in a way she'd never noticed before.

It was overwhelming... but also comforting.

She chose something simple—a single flower nearby, its petals open wide to the sun. A small, pale bloom swaying gently in the wind.

As she focused, something extraordinary happened.

Mami gasped softly, her breath hitching as the sensation overtook her. Suddenly, she wasn't just observing the flower.

She *was* the flower.

She felt herself rooted in the earth, the soil cool and nourishing around her base. The sun poured warmth onto her petals, and the breeze danced through her like a caress. There was no fear, no hurry. Just the rhythm of nature. The presence of bees landing softly, gathering pollen. Their weight was light, barely a tickle, but she could feel them. The scent of herself—sweet, subtle, and bright—drifted in the air.

The peace of it made her heart ache.

Then, shifting her focus, she moved again—this time to a bee.

It was like slipping into another world.

She felt the world shift in scale—so vast now, with every flower a vibrant beacon in a landscape of color and scent. Her wings beat rapidly, her body humming with energy as she drifted through the air. She could taste the pollen on the wind, see ultraviolet hues invisible to human eyes. The world was beautiful—intensely so. Every bloom she landed on, every bit of nectar gathered, was part of a quiet harmony, purposeful and free.

Mami's heart swelled. She'd never seen nature this way. Not with her eyes.

But now... she felt it.

It was a world alive not just with motion, but with *meaning*.

And she was part of it.

After some time in that state—buzzing, blooming, breathing with the world—Mami slowly let herself return.

Her breath deepened. Her awareness drew inward again. The bee's wings, the flower's roots, the pulse of nature surrounding her... faded gently into the background.

She opened her eyes.

The grove shimmered with life in a way it hadn't before—not because it had changed, but because *she* had. Everything felt closer now. More vibrant. Real.

Without a word, Mami rose to her feet and walked quietly to the flower she had connected with. It was small and unassuming—nothing like the bold roses or ornate bouquets she might have admired before. But now...

She knelt beside it and touched the petals gently.

"Thank you," she whispered.

Then, slowly, she began to walk the grove.

She didn't rush. Every step brought her near something new—each leaf, each bloom, each vine and stalk felt like a living thread in the tapestry around her. She ran her fingers along soft moss growing at the base of a tree. Stopped to inhale the earthy scent of bark and flowers. Closed her eyes again when a soft breeze swept past, as if the wind itself was greeting her.

It was freeing in a way she'd never known.

Not as a magical girl.

Not even as a person.

She wasn't preparing for a fight. She wasn't analyzing, strategizing, bracing herself.

She was simply *being*.

She wasn't taking from nature. She wasn't trying to control it. She was part of it—accepted by it.

She smiled softly.

When she finally circled back to the center of the grove, she noticed Lunaria had opened her eyes. The older girl sat still and quiet, watching her with a serene smile—calm and proud.

“You look like you enjoyed yourself,” Lunaria said gently.

Mami laughed lightly, tucking a strand of hair behind her ear. “That’s an understatement.”

Lunaria tilted her head. “So... what did you see? What did you learn?”

Mami paused to gather her thoughts, then stepped forward, her eyes alight.

“It was... beautiful,” she said softly. “I connected with a flower first. I felt the warmth of the sun, the breeze, the bees landing on me. I wasn’t just seeing it—I *was* it. There was no fear. Just... peace. Purpose. And when I connected with the bee, it was like flying in a dream. The world was huge and colorful. Every flower was a universe. There was freedom. Joy. Simplicity.”

She looked around at the trees, the wind rustling the leaves overhead.

“And I realized something,” she continued. “Even though they’re so different—a flower and a bee—they’re connected. They each exist for themselves *and* each other. Like... a quiet agreement.”

Her gaze dropped to her hands, now resting loosely at her sides.

“I’ve spent so long thinking of magic as a weapon. As a burden. A survival tool. But this... this is different. It’s not about fighting. It’s about listening. Resonating. *Trusting*.”

She looked back to Lunaria, eyes glowing with a deeper understanding.

“And I want to learn more.”

Lunaria smiled, calm and warm. “I’m glad,” she said softly. “You’re starting to see magic differently. That matters.”

She stood and walked a few steps closer, letting the gentle breeze shift her cloak. “Magic, negativity, energy—none of it is good or bad on its own. It’s all about how we choose to use it. Just like now... your connection with nature brought peace, not destruction.”

She gave a small wink. “And as a bonus—what you did today is another method to build up your negativity endurance.”

Mami blinked in surprise before laughing. “So this was part of the training all along?”

Lunaria chuckled. “Everything connects together again, doesn’t it?”

Mami smiled, shaking her head. “I’m starting to see the pattern.”

“Good,” Lunaria said, clearly pleased. “Now let’s put that to use. I want you to try connecting with some of the nearby plants by **touching** them. See if you can draw out their essence—not to consume them, but to request a part of what they offer. You’re not taking. You’re aligning. Listening.”

“You mean how you and Kasumi create ingredients for meals?” Mami asked, eyes lighting up.

“Exactly. Simple ones to start,” Lunaria replied. “Plant life is easier to connect with than animals. I’ll take care of gathering lunch ingredients. You focus on practicing connect on the plants.”

Mami gave a sharp nod. “Alright. I’ll give it a try.”

She turned back to the grove, closed her eyes, and let her senses stretch out again.

This time, it wasn’t about losing herself in the beauty of a flower or the freedom of a bee. This was different—not full immersion, but a focused approach. A test of precision. Lunaria had made it sound gentle, intuitive—but Mami quickly realized how much discipline it required.

She inhaled slowly. Her mind wandered. She exhaled—gently nudging it back. Again and again.

Thoughts crept in: **Am I doing this right? What if I overreach? What if I can’t feel anything this time?**

No. Focus.

She grounded herself in the feeling of the earth beneath her boots, the sun against her face, the magic flowing lightly through her soul gem. Then, like tuning an instrument to a pitch she could just barely hear, she began to sync.

Her awareness brushed the edge of a cluster of small herbs nestled near the base of a tree. They were simple—modest green leaves with delicate stems—but they carried a vibrancy.

Mami walked over to the herbs and **touched** them, letting her magic flow—not grabbing, not taking, just... resonating.

It was harder than she thought. Her energy trembled at first, pushing too hard, then recoiling. The herbs remained still, untouched.

Mami furrowed her brow and adjusted, pulling herself into a calmer state. Slower. Softer.

Let it be an offering, not a demand.

She aligned again.

This time, she felt it: the warmth stored in their leaves from hours of sunlight, the faint pulse of life drawing water up from the roots, the quiet presence of patience in their tiny veins.

And then—like a soft exhale—the herbs responded.

A glimmer, subtle as breath, shimmered at the edge of her awareness. Energy lifted, not stripped, but shared. A delicate spark drifting from leaf to soul gem. Not much. But enough.

Essence.

Mami gasped softly, eyes fluttering open.

There it was. A faint shimmer across the back of her glove. The sensation, clear and gentle in her soul gem. She blinked down at the herbs she had connected with—unchanged, still rooted, still whole.

She hadn't taken anything away.

She'd simply... shared in what was already there.

And the smile that rose to her lips wasn't just from pride. It was from gratitude.

She had done it. For the first time—truly, gently—she had *connected*.

Later, the two of them walked side by side down the forest path, the cabin coming into view.

Their baskets were light but filled with vibrant magical ingredients—humble pieces of a shared experience.

“So... does this mean lunch is technically magical now?” Mami asked, half-grinning.

Lunaria gave a gentle laugh. “It always was.”

They continued on, chatting easily, light-footed as the breeze that passed through the trees around them.

And for a moment, Mami wasn't just learning magic.

She was living it.

Chapter 3b: Wings in Motion

A shimmer of golden light danced in the air as Kasumi stepped through the veil and into Kamihama City. The sky was bright, the streets busy, and energy hummed faintly through her boots.

Before long, she found herself strolling through a quiet side street, where the sounds of chatter and footsteps guided her toward familiar voices.

“Ah-ha! Found you~!”

Four girls turned at once—each distinct in style and energy. Iroha looked surprised, Tsuruno beamed with her usual fiery grin, Sana peeked out from behind her hood, and Felicia raised an eyebrow but smiled the moment she saw who it was.

Kasumi raised a hand in a cheerful wave. “Yo! Iroha, Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia—good to see you again! Thanks for the good time last night!”

“Kasumi-san?” Iroha blinked, then smiled warmly. “Nice seeing you again. What brings you here?”

Kasumi grinned. “Oh, you know~ Adventuring! I was curious about the Kamihama rumors Yachiyo mentioned yesterday.” She leaned in slightly, hands behind her back. “I was hoping to ask her more about them. Where are you all headed?”

Tsuruno answered with dramatic flair. “To the Memory Museum! We got an invite from someone... suspicious.”

Sana nodded quietly. “Mifuyu... she visited us last night. She invited us to a group called the Wings of the Magius. They say they want to save magical girls from their fate.”

Kasumi’s expression sharpened just slightly—but her tone remained light. “Save them, huh? Sounds noble. And where’s Yachiyo?”

There was a pause. Iroha’s gaze dropped.

Felicia scoffed, crossing her arms. “She’s pissed off.”

Iroha explained gently, “Mifuyu and Yachiyo used to be close friends, but... Yachiyo didn’t take it well when she saw her again. She’s upset that Mifuyu joined the Wings. Especially since that group’s done some shady stuff before—like using Uwasu to control people.”

“She hasn’t really been herself since last night,” Sana added softly.

Kasumi listened, her usual brightness dimming to a thoughtful calm. “Thanks for telling me. It’s interesting. Saving magical girls sounds like a good goal... but if they’re hurting others along the way...” She trailed off, eyes narrowing just a bit. *I wonder how they plan to save magical girls...* Kasumi thought.

That flicker of conviction lit her expression—but it vanished just as quickly, replaced by her signature grin.

“Well! Since I’m already here with you,” she said, clapping her hands, “Mind if I tag along? I’d love to see how Kamihama magical girls handle their business.”

Tsuruno gave a thumbs-up. “Of course! We could use the extra firepower!”

Felicia grinned. “I love your energy! Let’s go!”

Iroha nodded with a grateful smile. “We’d be happy to have you.”

Kasumi gave a playful little bow. “Then let the adventuring continue~!”

And together, they walked through the city toward the Memory Museum, unaware of the tangled webs waiting for them inside.

Chapter 3c: Inside the Memory Museum

Kasumi and the magical girls stepped through the ornate entrance of the Memory Museum. The hall stretched wide and mysterious, lined with towering shelves and glowing glass cases—everything bathed in a surreal hush. The air shimmered faintly with magic, like the breath of a memory long held. Every step echoed, quiet but deliberate, as if even sound was careful not to disturb the past.

At the heart of the gallery stood two figures: Touka, seated regally on a red velvet chair, parasol leaning gracefully beside her; and Mifuyu, poised by her side, calm but authoritative.

Touka's gaze landed on Kasumi and the group. She smiled, nodding with polite curiosity. "Welcome. And who might this be?"

Iroha spoke quickly, a hint of admiration in her voice. "This is Kasumi! You know... Kasumi the world-adventurer. She performed at the talent show last night—blew us all away."

Kasumi bowed theatrically, grinning under the glow of the museum lights. "A pleasure, truly. The stage was full of amazing energy—thanks for having me!"

Mifuyu's eyes lit with faint recognition. "Ah... yes. We saw your performance through the venue's broadcast. It was quite stirring."

Touka nodded, a small smile tugging at her lips. "You sang with conviction. It felt as though you were speaking to us directly. To magical girls."

Kasumi placed a hand over her heart and gave a playful smile. "Then I'm honored. That song was... for anyone carrying a weight no one else can see. Magical girls most of all."

Tsuruno added helpfully, "We had dinner with her and her friends last night—Kasumi, and two others. They were great! We still don't really know who they are, though..."

"Yeah," Felicia said, tilting her head. "Dunno if she's a magical girl or not, but she sure knows a lot about us."

Mifuyu's expression cooled slightly. Her eyes narrowed with quiet suspicion. "How do you know about magical girls just from... traveling?"

Kasumi didn't blink. She kept her smile intact, though it softened in tone. "I cross paths with many people in my journeys. Some are magical girls. Some aren't. But everywhere I go, I listen. I learn. I've shared stories, meals, and songs with girls who carry burdens most never see. Some I've helped... some have helped me." She tilted her head slightly. "Like last night."

Mifuyu's gaze drifted to Kasumi's hands—no ring, no soul gem in sight. Her suspicion deepened, but before she could speak again, Touka gently touched her arm.

"It's alright," Touka said with an airy calm, smiling toward Kasumi. "We all arrive here from different paths. I believe today's lecture will be quite... educational. For everyone." Her eyes glimmered. "Welcome to the Memory Museum, Kasumi."

Kasumi gave a playful little bow. “Glad to be here. I do love a good lecture.”

Touka turned, her voice lilting through the chamber. “Then please. Follow me.”

And so, the group stepped deeper into the museum, unaware of just how deep the memories—and the truths—waiting for them truly went.

As they were walking, Iroha caught Touka’s eye and swallowed before asking softly, “By the way, Touka... I’ve seen you in my dreams. Do you know about my sister, Ui?”

Touka’s expression remained unreadable. “I do not know that name,” she replied gently.

Iroha’s hopeful smile faltered. “...You don’t?”

Touka shook her head once. Calm. Distant. “No. That name does not exist in my memories.”

Iroha’s face fell. Felicia muttered something under her breath. Even Tsuruno looked uncertain.

Kasumi’s heart skipped.

That didn’t sound like a lie.

The admission dropped into the room with unexpected weight. Kasumi’s heart skipped. *Touka... Ui... the Wings... Saving all magical girls...* All these threads were pulling tight—leading somewhere, she could tell.

A hush stretched across the group.

Touka cleared her throat, regal and calm, her parasol a silent presence. “Welcome to the Wings of the Magius lecture. Please, take your seats.”

Kasumi gave a subtle nod, masking the sharp edge of her focus with a curious smile. The deeper this went, the more it felt like her journey hadn’t led her here by chance.

The adventure was deepening. But so was the danger.

Chapter 3d: Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson One

The lights dimmed ever so slightly in the Memory Museum’s presentation hall, as if the room itself were leaning in to listen. Touka, ever poised and theatrical, stepped forward. Her parasol rested behind her chair now, and the soft tap of her shoes echoed across the marble floor.

“Let us begin,” she announced, her voice clear and filled with the rhythm of a practiced performer. “Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson One.”

She turned to a large display behind her, and with a flick of her hand, a projection shimmered into view: an illustrated girl with wide eyes and a hopeful smile.

“Once upon a time,” Touka began, “there was a girl. Ordinary, kind, full of dreams. One day, she encountered a strange creature who offered her a contract. In exchange for a wish—any wish—she would become a magical girl, capable of fighting witches and protecting those she loved.”

The display shifted, showing the girl transformed—clad in bright colors, wielding a weapon, charging into battle.

“She fought bravely. Tirelessly. Her soul gem shining bright. Until... one day... it didn’t.”

The image darkened. Cracks formed on the soul gem in the projection. The girl was shown mid-battle—eyes wide, gem in hand—as it shattered.

Touka turned to the audience with a gentle smile. “So... what do you think happened to our brave little heroine?”

She pointed to one of the attending magical girls near the front. “You there.”

The girl blinked, startled. “U-uh... she can’t use magic anymore?”

Touka grinned and made a loud “Bzzzzzt!” sound, swiping her finger across her neck. “Wrong~! But a very common misconception.”

Another girl hesitantly raised her hand. “Maybe... she just stops being a magical girl?”

Touka gave a playful shrug. “Closer, but still—Bzzzzzt!”

She then turned, eyes glittering, to Kasumi. “How about you, Miss Enigma~? Care to take a wild guess?”

Kasumi, lounging ever-so-comfortably in her chair, put a finger to her chin. Her smile widened into something mischievous. “Ohohoho... very well~”

She stood and dramatically threw one arm in the air. “Clearly, she becomes a deranged, wandering zombie! One who haunts the battlefield, cursed to roam the Earth in search of her shattered soul gem!” She began a theatrical stagger around her seat, moaning and waving her arms. “Wooo~ Despair~ I need more soul gem fragments~ Woooo!”

A few girls giggled nervously. **Felicia tried not to laugh but failed miserably, doubling over with a snort.** Even Tsuruno cracked a grin, covering her mouth.

Mifuyu, however, arched an eyebrow. Her expression didn’t shift much—still calm, still composed—but her eyes lingered on Kasumi a beat longer than necessary. Calculating. Curious. **As if trying to decide whether the energetic adventurer was ignorant, mocking the lesson... or hiding something.**

Touka clapped once, laughing brightly. “**Bzzzzzt! Oh, absolutely incorrect—but wonderfully delivered!**”

Kasumi slumped back into her seat with a mock sigh of defeat. “**Alas, foiled by curriculum again~**”

But her smirk said something else.

Kasumi knew the truth.

I'll keep feigning ignorance for now.

Touka regained her composure and raised a single finger. “The truth is far simpler. And far more tragic.”

She turned back to the projection. “When a magical girl’s soul gem breaks... the magical girl dies.”

Gasps spread through the crowd.

Iroha’s mouth fell open. “Dies...?”

“But... why?” Sana whispered, clutching her sleeves.

Touka didn’t flinch. “Because when you become a magical girl, your soul is removed from your body and placed into the soul gem. That gem is your soul now. Your true self. Your body is simply a shell—an animated vessel for your soul’s will. Destroy the gem, and the vessel ceases to move.”

A long, stunned silence followed.

Only Kasumi remained composed—feigning a shocked hand to her mouth, eyes wide in exaggerated horror. “Oh no~ What a twist~”

Touka’s voice dropped into something slightly more biting. “And to think... so many magical girls don’t even realize this. I find it rather shocking that no one told you something so... basic.”

Her words hung in the air like a blade suspended over truth itself.

Chapter 3e: Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson Two

Touka straightened with a theatrical flourish, arms wide. “You’ve all passed the first lesson—some of you with more flair than accuracy,” she added with a smirk toward Kasumi, who gave an exaggerated bow in return.

“Now,” Touka continued, “you’re ready for *Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson Two*. Please follow Mifuyu. She will show you... the heart of what this is all about.”

Mifuyu stepped forward, calm and elegant as ever, gesturing with a graceful sweep of her hand. “This way.”

The group followed her down a quiet corridor, the Memory Museum’s atmosphere growing ever more dreamlike—hallways curving gently like the inside of a shell, light shifting subtly as they moved. Eventually, they arrived at what appeared to be an old-fashioned gondola, suspended in a softly glowing shaft of magical energy.

Felicia raised an eyebrow. “Uh... are we going up?”

“Yes,” Mifuyu replied. “But not how you expect.” She ushered them inside. “This gondola is connected to my soul gem’s memory archive. It’s not just for movement—it’s for *understanding*. For you to truly grasp what magical girls endure... you must see it through our eyes.”

The group exchanged uncertain glances but filed in. Kasumi was the last to step in, her eyes lingering briefly on the elegant details of the gondola’s interior—wrought iron vines, velvet cushions, and golden fixtures that glowed with soft enchantment.

The moment the doors closed, the motion began—gently swaying upward, as though floating on air. The hum of magic filled the chamber.

One by one, the girls began to doze off—Tsuruno slumping forward with a soft sigh, Sana’s head tipping against Felicia’s shoulder, Felicia groaning sleepily before curling into the corner. Iroha’s eyes fluttered, and she drifted off quietly, hands in her lap.

Kasumi observed in silence, eyes half-lidded.

Interesting, so the Wings of the Magius can share memories with each other...

She leaned back, relaxed her breathing, and allowed her mind to slip into the rhythm of the gondola’s pull.

Let’s see what memories you’re willing to show me, Mifuyu.

Darkness fell—and then light returned.

Kasumi opened her eyes and found herself standing in a warm, sunlit villa.

The air smelled of fresh herbs and old stone, the kind of grounding scent that whispered of slow mornings and well-worn routines. Pale golden tiles stretched beneath her feet, gleaming under shafts of light that poured in through tall windows. Somewhere nearby, the soft clatter of dishes and faint laughter echoed through the walls.

She moved slowly, drawn toward the open archway that led to the garden.

There—just outside—were a group of girls. Young. Bright. So full of life and promise. They moved like they belonged to each other. Cooking, sparring, laughing. No walls between them. No hesitation in their trust.

At the center of it all were two familiar faces—though they were younger, less guarded.

Mifuyu, with softer features and a relaxed smile, knelt in the grass, pouring tea into delicate cups while one of the others tried to arrange flowers into her hair. Yachiyo stood nearby, training with one of the other girls in graceful, precise movements. Her expression was focused, but not cold—not the sharp, distant gaze Kasumi had seen in the present. She even laughed at one point—openly.

Kasumi smiled faintly. *So that's what she used to be like...* she thought. *Yachiyo was still sharp, still strong—but warmer somehow. And Mifuyu... even then, there was steel beneath her smile.* She paused. *They both had that same watchfulness. Even back then. I remember how they looked at me... like they were trying to see through me. Not unkind, but cautious.*

A quiet voice stirred beside her.

“These are my memories,” Mifuyu said, now standing beside Kasumi in the same pristine white dress as before. Her voice was soft, almost reverent. “You and the others are only observers here. No one can see or hear you.”

Kasumi nodded slowly, eyes fixed on the living snapshot before her. One of the girls had burned a stew and the others burst out laughing, Mifuyu waving her arms in mock horror. Another girl swept in dramatically to salvage the meal. The teasing, the chaos, the quiet joy—it all felt so... real.

And yet it was a memory.

Kasumi's smile turned wistful. “They trained together. Laughed together. Look at them—cooking, cleaning, joking around. You even had a garden.” She exhaled slowly. “A shared home... magical girls supporting each other like a real family. It's honestly beautiful.”

Mifuyu said nothing for a long moment.

Kasumi turned to her, expecting agreement. Maybe even a touch of nostalgia or pride.

But Mifuyu only offered a small smile—serene, composed... and terribly sad.

The weight of it lingered in the air like dust in a quiet room.

Kasumi didn't press. But in her chest, something tightened.

What happened to you two? she thought. *What broke this?*

The 1st realization – Magical girl's soul gem

Mifuyu stepped forward slightly, gazing out at the memory like someone revisiting a dream just before it turns into a nightmare.

“We lived happily for a time,” she said quietly. “We trained together, cooked meals, fought witches... celebrated each other's birthdays.” Her voice softened. “When we lost, we leaned on each other. When we won, we danced in the kitchen and told jokes until sunrise.”

Kasumi looked at the younger versions of the girls again. They *had* been happy. Radiantly so. But that glow was starting to fade—something unseen, inevitable, just over the horizon.

Mifuyu turned to her, eyes distant. “But then... one day, during a fight, everything changed.”

The sunlight dimmed.

In the blink of an eye, the villa around them dissolved. Stone and tile gave way to rusted metal and foggy air—the unmistakable confines of a witch’s labyrinth. It stretched in impossible angles, full of smoke and malevolent whispers.

Kasumi’s expression tightened, and she took a quiet step forward.

Below her now, a scene played out like a projected memory—Yachiyo, Mifuyu, and another girl, Kanae, locked in a fierce battle. The witch loomed before them, grotesque and massive, its movements erratic and aggressive. Binding tendrils shot from its form, weaving and snapping through the air like barbed wire.

Ah, Kasumi thought, eyes flicking over the movements with practiced precision. Strong type. Wide-area suppression. Mental interference layer too, judging by that flicker in Mifuyu’s step. And those runes—

She grinned to herself in her thoughts. Kanae’s not just brute force. She’s baiting the witch’s fire patterns. Clever girl.

But she said none of this aloud. Not here. Not while Mifuyu was reliving this moment.

Below, Yachiyo and Mifuyu were caught—entangled in magical bindings that pinned them in place. The witch roared, preparing a charged energy beam aimed straight at them. Panic crossed their faces.

Oh, no. Look at those bindings—fast, precise, and unrelenting. Classic suppression technique, Kasumi thought, eyes gleaming with excitement. Yachiyo’s trying to reach her magic gem, but those seals are blocking her energy flow. Mifuyu’s struggling to keep calm, but the strain’s showing.

And then—

Kanae moved.

She threw herself in front of the blast with no hesitation. Her shield expanded, catching the brunt of the witch’s attack. Light exploded outward as her soul gem flared violently.

Now that’s courage. Full commitment. She’s the anchor of the team—no hesitation, no second-guessing. Watch the shield pulse! That’s soul gem energy at maximum output. If she holds this...

From the shadow beside Kasumi, Mifuyu’s voice dropped.

“You’re about to see... Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson One... in action.”

Kasumi’s smile vanished.

Down in the memory, Kanae’s soul gem began to crack. Thin, spiderweb-like lines etched across its surface. Her hands trembled, her body pushing beyond its limit.

There it is. The stress fractures. That’s the tipping point, the critical danger zone. Every moment she holds this shield, the risk grows exponentially. It’s a race against time.

But still, she held on—just long enough to redirect the beam with her final burst of energy.

Yes! Look at that! She's channeling every last drop of power into the counterattack—sending that beam right back where it came from!

The witch screeched and disintegrated in a shower of fragments. The labyrinth trembled—and then faded entirely, breaking apart into motes of light.

Victory, but at what cost? That gem won't hold much longer...

The scene shifted to the real world again.

Yachiyo and Mifuyu, panting and wide-eyed, rushed toward Kanae, who lay collapsed in the grass, her weapon dropped beside her.

They were smiling. Laughing in relief.

“You did it!” Mifuyu said, kneeling down.

Yachiyo knelt beside her. “Kanae! That was amazing. You saved us.”

But Kanae didn't respond.

Their smiles began to falter.

Mifuyu touched her arm. “Kanae?”

Yachiyo leaned in, her hand moving to Kanae's wrist. “Wait...”

The camera of the memory seemed to hold still—as if even the dream didn't want to show what came next.

“No pulse...” Yachiyo whispered.

Mifuyu reached for Kanae's soul gem—and her hand froze.

It was shattered. Completely. Not cracked. Not dulled.

Gone.

“No...” Mifuyu whispered, her voice trembling. “No, no, no—Kanae, no—”

Yachiyo didn't move. Her eyes stared blankly at the broken gem in her friend's palm.

The scene cracked like porcelain—emotion flooding in like water behind glass.

Kasumi watched in stillness. She didn't speak. She didn't move. She just stared, her chest tight.

They didn't know.

Mifuyu's voice returned, almost a whisper. "That was the first time we truly understood what it meant to be magical girls. We had fought witches. We had struggled. But we didn't know what we had given up."

The scene below froze, the three girls held in eternal tragedy.

"No one ever told us," Mifuyu continued. "No one ever explained. Until that moment, we believed we were just... strong girls fighting evil. We never knew the truth. About the soul gem. About what we had really become."

Kasumi's hand tightened at her side.

She looked again at the younger Yachiyo, who now clutched her dead friend's body, shaking as tears streamed down her face. Her mouth moved, but no sound came through the memory.

So this is why Yachiyo became distant. And why Mifuyu joined the Wings, Kasumi thought. These memories...

She said nothing aloud.

And Mifuyu, standing beside her in the quiet, still smiled that same sad smile—like a ghost who had lived this moment too many times to cry anymore.

2nd realization – witches

The shattered labyrinth dissolved into soft white, and the world around Kasumi shifted again.

When the light settled, she found herself once more in the villa—but it looked different now. The golden afternoon sun spilled through the windows, casting long, warm shadows. The air was calm. Familiar.

Laughter echoed faintly from the hall.

In the courtyard, Kasumi saw more girls this time—new faces among the old. Momoko was playfully bickering with one of the others over who made the better tea. Mel was leaning against a tree, reading a book and giggling at something whispered by another girl beside her. The atmosphere was peaceful. Joyful. Alive.

Mifuyu stood beside Kasumi, her hands folded in front of her as she watched the scene quietly.

"After Kanae passed," she began softly, "Yachiyo and I... we fell apart for a time. The grief was too deep. Our hearts were heavy, and the guilt was unbearable. Some days, we didn't even speak."

She turned slightly, her gaze distant.

"But slowly... we found reasons to live again. We met more girls. We opened our hearts. And in time, this place—this villa—became a home again. Not one without sorrow... but full of warmth. Support. Family."

Kasumi's eyes took in the serenity of the courtyard. The way the girls moved through the space with casual affection—sharing food, throwing towels over shoulders, teasing one another like siblings. She could feel the bond between them even now, in the echoes of memory.

Kasumi grinned, her eyes sparkling as she watched the peaceful scene unfold.

“Heh... you know, that’s honestly amazing.” She placed her hands on her hips, chin lifted proudly. “Most people would’ve been crushed after what you went through. But you? You two picked yourselves up, and you built something new—something beautiful. That’s real strength, right there!”

She turned toward Mifuyu, her expression softening just a bit—but still glowing with warmth.

“I’m seriously impressed, Mifuyu. You and Yachiyo... you didn’t just survive. You *lived*. That deserves respect.”

And then, with a theatrical flourish, Kasumi gave her a deep, cheerful bow. “From one girl to another: I salute you~!”

Mifuyu blinked in surprise, then let out a quiet, breathy laugh. “Thank you, Kasumi-san. That... means more than you know.”

But her smile soon faded, her gaze shifting forward again, where the courtyard began to blur—colors bleeding into shadow.

The laughter dulled. The light dimmed.

Another memory stirred.

And this one would not be kind.

The memory shifted again.

Kasumi blinked—and now they stood within a dense, colorful forest, painted in unnatural hues. Trees stretched impossibly tall, their leaves tinged with violet and teal. The air shimmered with static, and strange shadowy arms writhed through the atmosphere, brushing against bark and sky alike.

It was a witch’s labyrinth.

The wind picked up, carrying with it an ominous, dissonant hum.

Four magical girls stood at the center of it: Yachiyo, Mifuyu, Momoko, and Mel—together, weapons drawn, eyes locked ahead.

Kasumi’s eyes lit up.

Oooh, here we go! A dramatic fight in a forest labyrinth. Tricky terrain, eerie vibes... tons of movement and cover. Perfect setting for an ambush—or a comeback! Alright, girls—show me what you’ve got!

The Witch materialized from the gloom, its grotesque, towering form rising above the treetops. It was misshapen—half-mask, half-body—its long, gangly arms each clutched a massive cone-shaped spike, which it used to stab violently at anything in its path. With a distorted screech, it launched its attack.

Chains of energy and jagged limbs shot forward, slashing at the group from every angle.

The girls moved quickly, scattering and engaging, but the Witch was relentless. For every blow they dodged, two more followed. The deeper they fought into the labyrinth, the more erratic the space became—trees warping, gravity twisting. And yet, the girls held formation.

But it wouldn't last.

Below, Yachiyo gritted her teeth. "Mifuyu! Mel! Get out of here! Momoko, clear a path!"

Momoko swung her great sword wide, slamming back a wave of familiars and creating an opening.

"What about you?!" Mel shouted, disbelief etched across her face.

"I can handle it!" Yachiyo shouted, already leaping toward the Witch with spear in hand. "Go!"

Kasumi watched from above, her breath catching just a little.

Bold move. Solo charge against a high-level target. Girl's got guts—classic warrior move; a warrior after my own heart! But also... reckless. Not that I'm one to talk.

Yachiyo danced between strikes, landing blow after blow, spinning through the Witch's attacks like a storm. She blocked, parried, countered—but the Witch didn't slow. Its arms surged in from all sides, each wielding a brutal, cone-shaped spike, converging in a crushing barrage.

Too many. She can't block them all. She's exposed.

Then—

"YACHIYO!!"

Mel dashed forward.

Kasumi's smile faded.

No... not her too.

"Mel, don't!!" Yachiyo screamed.

But Mel was already there, launching a desperate blast of magic, intercepting the Witch's attack. A blinding flash consumed the rooftop.

When it faded, the fight was over.

The Witch was gone.

But so was something else.

They were back on the ground now. Mel lay collapsed, breathing faint and shallow. Her Soul Gem, once vibrant, was now caked in dark sludge—clouded and flickering.

Yachiyo and the others surrounded her, voices shaking.

“We don’t have time,” Momoko said urgently. “The Witch escaped. No grief seed...”

Yachiyo gripped Mel’s hand tightly. “Stay with us. I’ll find one. I’ll bring it back. You’re going to be alright.”

Mel weakly shook her head. “Yachiyo... it’s no use. I can feel it. I... I’m going to—”

And then it happened.

Her Soul Gem cracked, then shattered.

A pulse of darkness erupted outward.

Kasumi didn’t flinch as a monstrous silhouette took shape in Mel’s place. The grotesque form twisted in on itself—familiar... and no less tragic.

The other three girls dropped to their knees, staring in wide-eyed horror.

“No...” Mifuyu whispered, voice barely audible. “Mel... What happened? This can’t be real.”

“No, Mel, no—! What’s going on?!” Momoko cried out, her voice breaking with panic.

Yachiyo said nothing. Her face drained of color, hands trembling at her sides. *One of my friends... again.*

From beside Kasumi, current Mifuyu turned her gaze toward her, quiet but direct.

“...Tell me, Kasumi. What happens to magical girls in the end?”

Kasumi hesitated, just for a beat. Then she put on her usual playful smirk.

“Well,” she said softly, “if their soul gets too cloudy... they become witches, right?”

Mifuyu nodded solemnly. “Correct. Fundamentals of Magical Girls Theory—Lesson Two. It’s one thing to be told the truth. It’s another to see it with your own eyes.”

Kasumi watched the scene—frozen in time—as Mel’s Witch form hovered above her grieving friends. Her eyes were narrowed, focused. But her expression had shifted... more serious now.

So that’s the truth you’ve decided to show them. Same as what we did with Mami. Threw her straight into the storm.

I guess Lunaria and I are no different.

But still... the Wings of the Magius. You’re a strange bunch. Sharing memories, teaching secrets, carrying the weight of impossible truths. Hmm...

Kasumi tilted her head slightly, eyes flicking toward Mifuyu out of the corner of her eye. *This is getting interesting! These girls in Kamihama really know their stuff. Let's see what happens next.*

Salvation for magical girls – doppel

The scene shifted again, returning to the villa bathed in soft afternoon light. Yachiyo, Mifuyu, and Momoko stood in a tight cluster, their faces pale, hearts heavy with grief. Kyubey hovered nearby, its unsettling smile fixed as ever.

“Kyubey,” Yachiyo’s voice cracked but held steady, “explain to us—what exactly happened to Mel?”

Kyubey’s small, gleaming eyes reflected no emotion. “Her soul gem became contaminated with darkness—muddy. When it shattered, the accumulated energy was released, and she transformed into a witch.”

Momoko’s hands clenched into fists, her voice rising sharply. “Why didn’t you tell us this before? You knew this could happen—and you *hid* it! So, we’ve been fighting magical girls who were once our allies? The whole time?”

Kyubey’s tone was clinical, unbothered. “Because you never asked. And besides, it is a necessary part of the cycle. The transformation from magical girl to witch is inevitable once the soul gem becomes fully tainted. This process, while tragic for individuals, sustains the energy balance required for the universe’s continued existence.”

Mifuyu’s eyes flashed with frustration and disbelief. “And what about us? What about the hope we held onto? What’s the point of continuing if this is our fate?”

Kyubey’s unsettling smile didn’t falter. “I do not experience emotions as you do. I cannot comprehend the fear, anger, and despair that all magical girls feel. But these emotions do not change the necessity of the system. You will come to accept it eventually.”

Yachiyo’s voice hardened, anger rising through her despair. “You expect us to accept this—our friends, our family, consumed by darkness—and you call it ‘necessary’? This isn’t a cycle. It’s a curse.”

Kyubey tilted its head slightly, a faint, almost mocking glimmer in its eyes. “I cannot grasp your emotional attachments. I merely fulfill the functions required. You are free to feel as you will. But understand—resistance only prolongs suffering.”

The girls fell silent, the cold weight of Kyubey’s logic pressing heavily on their hearts.

Without ceremony, Kyubey floated toward the exit. But at the doorway, it paused and looked back with an impassive expression.

“I have observed countless magical girls across many eras. Every one has voiced the same despair and anger—before ultimately surrendering to their fate. Your struggle is not unique, but it is yours.”

With that final, cryptic remark, Kyubey hopped out the window, leaving the girls alone in the villa, their minds swirling with doubt, sorrow, and a desperate need for answers.

Kasumi watched silently from the shadows, her thoughts burning brighter than ever.

So, they learn about the truth of magical girls. I wonder how they would take it. How do the Wings of the Magius plan to save all magical girls knowing this...

Current Mifuyu turned from the fading memory, her voice low and steady.

"Every time something terrible happened to one of us... we uncovered another dark truth about magical girls."

Her gaze lingered in the air, distant, haunted.

The memory shifted again.

Now it was night. Rain slicked empty streets in a city unfamiliar and uncaring. Kasumi saw a younger Mifuyu wandering aimlessly, her coat damp, her posture defeated. Her eyes were hollow. Her steps slow. A shadow of the girl she had seen before.

What am I even living for anymore...?

What's the point...?

Would it be better if I just... disappeared...?

Kasumi's brows furrowed slightly. She recognized that look. That spiral.

And then—an explosion of black light.

It engulfed the street.

Mifuyu's form vanished within it—and for a moment, she looked like she had become a witch.

Kasumi eyes squinted.

Wait... is that?

But then—

The darkness receded.

And Mifuyu was lying on the ground, unconscious. Back in human form.

Her soul gem, once filthy and dark, now glowed with renewed brilliance.

From the shadows stepped another figure.

Touka.

Smiling. Composed. Confident.

"That," she said, her voice echoing as she walked forward, "is how we plan to save magical girls."

With a flick of her parasol, Touka snapped her fingers.

The memory rewound a few seconds—back to the moment just after the explosion—and paused.

Kasumi stared.

The creature floating above Mifuyu was strange and elegant, eerie in its beauty. Massive. Ribbon-draped. Its form shimmered with the same glow as her soul gem.

“That,” Touka declared proudly, “is Mifuyu’s **Doppel**.”

She turned slightly toward Kasumi.

“The Automatic Purification System—**APS** for short—now surrounds all of Kamihama. It is our gift to magical girls. Under its influence, when a soul gem would normally collapse into despair and transform into a witch... the system intervenes.”

Touka gestured upward as the memory resumed in slow motion.

The doppel hovered in the air for a few moments, then faded.

Mifuyu’s form reappeared—unconscious, but intact. Her soul gem gleamed, purified and whole.

“A magical girl doesn’t become a witch. She becomes a **doppel** instead—a manifestation of her negative emotions. When the doppel fades, the girl returns to normal. Soul gem: clean. Grief: expelled. Hope... preserved.”

Kasumi remained silent, her eyes sharp.

So this is their answer to despair. A system that halts the transformation... at the brink. Replaces it with something new. A doppel, huh...?

This isn’t just damage control. It’s a full-scale revolution!

Touka continued with pride, “This is the fruit of our labor—me, Nemu, Alina!”

Kasumi tilted her head slightly, a small smile playing at the edge of her lips.

Touka, Mifuyu, Nemu, and Alina... the Wings of the Magius aren’t just dreamers. They’re engineers of salvation.

Interesting. Interesting indeed.

She crossed her arms, the smile fading just a bit.

I’m impressed they figured out something like this...

However... if they keep this up...

Touka’s voice echoed gently through the air, still brimming with pride. “Well then, Miss Kasumi... what do you think? How does our work compare to the magical girls you’ve met in your travels?”

Kasumi gave a small chuckle, then straightened up with a dazzling smile. “Honestly? I’m impressed.” She placed one hand on her hip and gestured animatedly with the other. “You found out the truth—the awful, soul-crushing truth—about magical girls. And yet here you are, not broken, not crying... but fighting. Moving forward. Trying to help others. That kind of strength? That’s rare. That’s real.” And then, with familiar flair, Kasumi bowed deeply. “Thanks for the lesson, professor~!”

Touka practically beamed. “Ufufu~! I knew you would understand! It’s not easy being this brilliant, but someone has to do it!”

Beside her, Mifuyu smiled as well—gently, solemnly. “Thank you, Kasumi. Truly. For someone like me... this is the only hope I have left. The only way to break free from the pain of being what we are.”

Kasumi straightened again, her expression shifting from dramatic admiration to thoughtful curiosity. “I’ve seen a lot in my travels. Magical girls trying to survive, trying to save others, trying to make sense of it all. But no one—no group—has ever created anything like this. A functioning, wide-area system to prevent witch transformations?”

She shook her head, genuinely awed. “That’s a whole new level.”

Then she paused. Her tone softened just a touch. “About those doppel forms... They looked amazing in the memory. Powerful. Liberating. But... are there any side effects?”

There are side effects... The girls can’t control that power... So if they use it too much, then... Kasumi kept the thought tucked behind her smile.

Touka’s smile held, but only just. She waved a hand with airy confidence, the flick of her parasol deliberate. “Side effects? Hm... well, I suppose there could be some. But nothing we’ve observed yet. Really, the system is quite stable! You have nothing to worry about.”

Kasumi caught the flicker in her voice—a beat too quick, too smooth. But she didn’t press. Instead, her smile widened ever so slightly, eyes glinting.

“That’s great to hear~ I hope it stays that way,” she said, her tone light... yet somehow lingering in the air like a distant warning.

The memory began to dissolve into light, the villa and stars peeling away like mist.

Chapter 4 – The World Yet to Know

As the final memory faded into glimmering particles, the dimmed lights of the Memory Museum flickered back to life. Kasumi blinked, adjusting to the return of reality—and found herself standing once more in the ornate chamber where it had all begun.

Touka stood to the side with her ever-present parasol in hand, a satisfied gleam in her eyes. Mifuyu was beside her, her expression soft and introspective.

Kasumi gave a respectful nod, then flashed a grin.

“Thanks for the experience. That was seriously something else,” she said with genuine enthusiasm.

“And Mifuyu—thank you for sharing all of that. I know it couldn’t have been easy.”

Mifuyu inclined her head, her voice warm. “I’m glad you could see it. Perhaps... understanding even a little helps lighten the weight.”

Touka spun her parasol once before resting it on her shoulder. “We do aim to educate~”

Kasumi placed her hands on her hips, curious spark reignited. “So... what’s next, then? You’ve shown me your story. What’s the next step in your grand plan, Miss Professor?”

Touka gave her a playful wink, sidestepping the question entirely. “Now, now, Miss Adventurer—you’ll just have to wait and see. But very soon, Kamihama will no longer be the exception. The *entire world* will be embraced by the Automatic Purification System.”

“The liberation of magical girls everywhere,” Mifuyu added, her tone wistful, almost prayerful.

Kasumi’s eyes shone, though behind the light was an unmistakable layer of analysis. She smiled knowingly. “Of course. I wouldn’t expect the Professor to give away her whole lecture before the exam.”

Touka chuckled, clearly delighted by the title. “Ufufu~ How very astute of you.”

“I’ll be looking forward to seeing it in action,” Kasumi said. “And after that... I think I’ll travel the world again. See how your invention plays out across the globe.”

Mifuyu’s gaze lifted at that, her smile touched with hope. “I feel the same. One day, all magical girls will be free from this suffering... I can’t wait for that day to come.”

Kasumi gave her a sincere smile and a wink. “I’m sure you’ll feel peace very soon.”

Something flickered behind her eyes, a meaning deeper than her words. Neither Touka nor Mifuyu seemed to catch it—but it lingered in the air like a whisper of something yet to come.

After a beat, Kasumi’s head tilted. “Oh—what about the other girls who came with me? I haven’t seen them around.”

Mifuyu answered calmly, though her eyes averted for the briefest moment. “They’ve chosen to join the Wings of the Magius. They were... moved by what they experienced.”

“I see,” Kasumi said lightly, but her expression remained sharp beneath the smile. *All of them? That fast? Hmm...*

Still, she didn’t press it.

“Well then,” Kasumi said brightly, turning on her heel, “I suppose this marks the end of this chapter in my journey. I’ll need time to digest everything—gotta jot it all down in my *Adventure Logs About Magical Girls™*, Vol. 9!”

As she strolled toward the grand exit, Touka called after her. “Oh, and Miss Enigma?”

Kasumi paused, glancing back over her shoulder.

Touka narrowed her eyes, her voice inquisitive but amused. “You’re quite an odd one. Are you... a magical girl or not? You don’t have a Soul Gem, but you’re not an ordinary human right?”

Mifuyu joined in, tone gentle but probing. “And... you didn’t react to those memories the way others do. It felt like... you already knew.”

Kasumi spun dramatically on her toe, arms outstretched. “What you see is what you get~! I’m Kasumi—the wandering adventurer, explorer of the world, and seeker of stories!”

She gave them a deep, theatrical bow. “Some call me strange, others mysterious—but I’m just me.”

With that, she turned again, walking toward the exit with a playful skip in her step. She waved a hand high in the air without looking back.

“Until next time~!”

The doors to the Memory Museum parted with a soft hum—and Kasumi disappeared into the light.

The grand doors of the Memory Museum closed gently behind her, leaving a soft echo in the silence that followed.

Touka stood still, eyes fixed on the spot where Kasumi had been only moments before. “Well then...” she mused aloud, tapping her parasol against her shoulder. “What *do* you think of our mysterious little explorer, Mifuyu?”

Mifuyu remained quiet for a moment, as if replaying the entire memory journey in her mind. “She’s... unusual,” she finally said, voice soft. “Energetic, certainly. Curious to a fault. But not in an arrogant way—more like she genuinely wants to understand.”

Touka smirked. “Mm, I noticed. She didn’t flinch during *any* of the memory sequences. Not even the transformation.”

“No,” Mifuyu agreed, folding her hands in front of her. “She watched everything with this... detached awareness. Not cold, but composed. Like someone who’s already seen things like that before.”

Touka tilted her head thoughtfully. “She’s not lying when she says she’s traveled the world. That’s the kind of calm you only gain after *a lot* of exposure to painful truths. But still...” She narrowed her eyes. “No Soul Gem. No contract signature. My intellect tells me she’s not a magical girl—but she’s not an ordinary human, either.”

“She’s hiding something,” Mifuyu said gently. “But not in a malicious way. I don’t think she came here to hurt us.”

Touka hummed, tapping her chin with one finger. “No, not yet at least. But she’s watching. Taking notes. Judging.”

“And smiling while doing it,” Mifuyu added, a faint grin tugging at the corner of her lips.

“Well,” Touka said, her eyes bright with curiosity, “I do love a good mystery.”

She turned back toward the museum hall, voice light but edged with focus.

“Let’s see where she pops up next, shall we?”

Kasumi was just stepping out of the Memory Museum when she nearly bumped into someone—a slender figure cloaked in dark, flowing clothes. The girl’s eyes were sharp, calm, yet held a quiet weariness.

“Oh! Hello there!” Kasumi chirped brightly, flashing her signature grin. “I’m Kasumi—the wandering adventurer, explorer of the world, and seeker of stories! And you are?”

The girl’s expression softened, a small, almost shy smile forming as she returned the introduction in kind. “I’m Kuroe. I used to fight witches alongside Iroha. I joined the Wings of the Magius hoping to be liberated from the sufferings that come with being a magical girl.”

Kasumi nodded thoughtfully. “A noble goal. Are you on your way somewhere?”

Kuroe glanced toward the direction Kasumi had come from. “Touka is about to give a speech to all the Wings of the Magius members. I’m headed there now.”

“Ah, the ‘Professor’ in action!” Kasumi’s eyes twinkled. “Thanks for the intro, Kuroe. What do you think of the Wings of the Magius and their grand plans? What have you heard about their work?”

Kuroe’s gaze drifted for a moment. “If you just saw Mifuyu’s memories, then I don’t know much beyond what you saw—the Automatic Purification System and the doppel forms. That it’s supposed to save magical girls across the world.” Her voice held a quiet uncertainty.

Kasumi’s mind whirled. *Just like Touka hid the full details from me... she must be keeping things from the Wings of the Magius members, too.*

Kuroe sighed softly, voice dropping to a more personal tone. “Honestly... I’ve always been scared of life-and-death battles. I’m weak compared to others. I just hope to become close with Iroha someday, to gain her trust and faith.”

Kasumi’s smile widened, sincere and warm. “Kuroe, surviving this long in a magical girl’s world without falling into despair? That takes strength of a rare kind. Keep your head high! You’re tougher than you think!”

Kuroe's lips curled into a genuine smile, gratitude shining in her eyes. "Thank you, Kasumi. That means a lot."

Kasumi gave a playful salute. "I wouldn't want to keep you hostage. Go on, hear the Professor's speech—sounds like it'll be a show!"

Before turning to leave, Kasumi gave Kuroe a knowing wink. "I expect we'll be meeting again very soon." With a cheerful wave, Kasumi continued on her way, her footsteps light and purposeful.

Kasumi wandered through the winding Kamihama streets, the lingering weight of Touka and Mifuyu's memories still swirling in her thoughts. Her eyes scanned the scenery until she caught sight of a small group of magical girls heading into a building tucked quietly along the edge of a residential block. Curious, as always, she followed.

The building wasn't flashy, but it had an inviting charm—almost like a personal clinic. A wooden sign out front read:

"Mitama Yakumo – Magical Girl Coordinator"

Kasumi's eyes lit up.

"Oho~? A magical girl coordinator lives here?" she whispered to herself. "Interesting... let's see what sort of things are being 'coordinated'."

She slipped in quietly, staying near the entrance. The group of magical girls ahead of her had already reached the counter, where a tall woman with long, silvery-lavender hair greeted them with a practiced smile. Mitama Yakumo.

Kasumi watched with great interest as the girls handed over grief seeds in exchange for bottles, charms, and other arcane-looking supplies. But it wasn't just items—they also asked Mitama for adjustments to their soul gems.

Mitama obliged, calmly placing her hand over each gem in turn, eyes closing as she worked. The magic was subtle but precise—small streams of light moved between her hands and the soul gems, altering something in their magical composition.

Kasumi narrowed her eyes slightly.

So these are soul gem adjustments... and that frequency—hm. She's tuning their gems... just like how Touka described the process to link a magical girl to a doppel.

She tucked the observation away mentally.

Mitama works with Touka. Maybe not part of the core leadership, but definitely a partner in all this.

Eventually, the group finished their transactions and gave Mitama polite bows before exiting. That was Kasumi's cue.

Grinning brightly, she approached the counter with a flamboyant twirl. "Helloooo there~! My name's Kasumi! Wandering adventurer, chronicler of magical girls across the globe, and lover of curious conversations! And you must be the coordinator of this lovely little place, yes?"

Mitama raised an eyebrow in amusement at the introduction, but her smile stayed in place. "You certainly make an entrance. Yes, I'm Mitama Yakumo. Magical girl coordinator of Kamihama. And you must be... the 'energetic adventurer' I heard about recently."

Kasumi tilted her head. "Oh~? News travels fast."

Mitama chuckled softly. "Touka and Mifuyu contacted me after your meeting. Said you were full of questions, observations, and global perspective. They had good things to say." Her smile deepened slightly. "I also watched your little performance with other magical girls during the Kamihama school talent show. I have to admit... it was unexpectedly moving."

She placed a hand over her chest, her expression gentler now. "You weren't just entertaining us—you were lifting our spirits. I could see it in their faces. Magical girls don't get many chances to laugh... or dream. For a few minutes, you reminded them what it's like to simply feel joy. That's not something I can adjust with magic. Thank you."

"Aw, how flattering! I just got out of a long—very long—lecture with them. Something about saving magical girls, doppel systems, the Automatic Purification System... y'know, light topics," Kasumi said with a playful wave of her hand. "And as for the talent show—ha! I'm glad you saw it. That was my favorite part of the trip so far. Sometimes, a silly little performance goes a long way, right?"

She leaned in slightly, eyes twinkling. "When I saw your sign, I had to check it out. I've met coordinators in other countries, but never one in Kamihama. I was curious what makes your work tick."

"Well, I'm a bit... unique," Mitama replied, her voice airy but calm. "I don't fight witches anymore. I use the grief seeds I earn through my services to maintain my own soul gem. And I help others in turn—adjusting soul gems, enhancing abilities, and lately... assisting with attunement to the Automatic Purification System doppel framework."

Kasumi nodded, her smile softening into genuine interest. "Sounds like you do a lot for magical girls here."

"I try," Mitama said. "It's not just a job for me. Magical girls suffer more than they deserve. If I can make that life even a little bit easier—or help them transition into this new system safely—it's worth it."

Kasumi folded her arms, taking that in thoughtfully. "That's admirable. Helping others without jumping into battle... but still on the front lines in your own way."

Mitama's eyes softened, and her voice carried a gentle warmth.

"Thank you. That's the dream, really—to give magical girls a space to breathe. And maybe... just maybe... be happy."

Kasumi nodded thoughtfully, her gaze steady. "That's a beautiful vision. Speaking of—which... are there any drawbacks to the doppel? I mean—saving magical girls is amazing, but nothing's ever perfect, right?"

Mitama paused, her calm expression flickering for a split second.

"There are... drawbacks," she admitted softly, voice steady but brief. "Some side effects. But... I'm not at liberty to discuss them in detail."

Kasumi watched her, absorbing the pause, the unspoken truth.

Another layer hidden. As expected—but I care more about the thread than the curtain.

She let the moment rest.

"I understand," Kasumi replied, her tone both respectful and tinged with subtle concern. "I just... hope the Wings of the Magius' plan—about doppel forms and the APS—doesn't end in disaster."

Mitama nodded slightly, as though moved by both the care and the underlying tension in Kasumi's words.

Kasumi flashed a bright, respectful smile at Mitama. "Thank you so much for your time—and for what you're doing here. I really appreciate it."

She began to turn and walk toward the door, but Mitama's voice floated after her softly.

"...Kasumi? Would you mind if I did a quick check-in?" Mitama asked casually, her voice smooth, calm—almost too calm. "Just to check on your well-being."

Kasumi paused mid-step, the faintest smirk tugging at the corner of her lips. That tone wasn't lost on her.

She turned around, hand on her hip, eyes gleaming with mischief. "A check-in? That would be great!" she chirped, clearly playing along. "You'll do the same routine as what you do with other magical girls, right? I'm very curious what you'll find."

She leaned in slightly, mock-whispering, "Just tell me... is it paid with a grief seed? Or is this one on the house?"

Mitama chuckled, a hand resting lightly over her chest. "This one's definitely on the house."

Kasumi extended her hands, palms up. "Then by all means, Miss Coordinator, the floor is yours~"

Mitama stepped forward, concentrating as she moved her hand slowly through the air above Kasumi, reaching out with her magical senses. The ritual was the same she'd done for countless other girls—feeling for the pulse of a Soul Gem, the tangle of emotional resonance, the traces of active magic.

But Kasumi?

Nothing.

No gem. No magical imprint. No despair. No grief. No hope. Just... stillness. A person, but somehow *more*, and *less*, all at once.

Mitama's brow furrowed subtly, though she quickly masked it. *Not even latent energy... She does not seem to be a magical girl...*

Mitama's fingers hovered a little longer above Kasumi's figure as she moved into the next phases of her standard check-in process—subtle scans, deeper attunements, sensory passes meant to detect minute fluctuations in magical resonance, the kind only magical girls radiated whether they realized it or not.

But with Kasumi...

Still nothing.

No trace of a magical contract. No residue from Grief Seeds. No backlash from casting. Not even the faintest ripple of enchantment in her aura.

Mitama straightened slowly, her expression thoughtful behind a professional smile. *Just who are you, Kasumi?*

She folded her hands neatly and offered a respectful nod. "Well... that concludes the check-up. Still no Soul Gem, no magical imprint, and not a drop of active magic. You really *aren't* a magical girl—at least, that is what it seems to me."

Kasumi blinked innocently. "Oh no~ What a scandal! Hope that doesn't ruin your perfect record."

Mitama laughed softly. "On the contrary. I'm impressed."

She tilted her head slightly, her tone shifting to something gentler, more genuine. "You've clearly studied magical girls deeply—and not just academically. You *understand* them. Their pain. Their hopes. Their burdens. And yet... you remain untouched. That kind of empathy is rare, even among our own."

She placed a hand lightly over her heart. "It warms me, truly, to know someone like you is out there. Even if you're not one of us... you still care. That means more than I can express."

Kasumi offered a flourishing bow, one arm across her chest, the other extended theatrically. "Aw~ You'll make me blush, Miss Coordinator. Thank you kindly for the *free* check-in! Your magical girl service is top notch~"

She stepped back toward the door with a light skip, turning briefly at the threshold to wave. “And I have a feeling this won’t be our last meeting. The world’s small when you keep chasing mysteries~!”

Mitama smiled, but said nothing. She watched as Kasumi vanished beyond the doorway, her steps light, her presence still oddly untraceable.

The room settled into silence again.

And Mitama, still gazing toward the exit, let out a soft breath. *Who are you really... Kasumi the Adventurer?*

Chapter 5 – Ripples Beneath the Surface

Sunlight danced upon the still surface of the lake, each ripple casting scattered beams of light onto the stone and flora that surrounded it. The air was fresh and tinged with a soft floral sweetness, blending with the distant calls of birds nesting in the trees.

Mami sat cross-legged at the edge of the water, her eyes closed, her soul calm. Beside her, as still as a statue and twice as serene, was **Lunaria**, her posture upright, her presence as gentle and quiet as the lake itself.

It was the same spot where Mami had once seen Lunaria play the harp and flute—a moment of such strange, haunting beauty it lingered in Mami’s heart like the notes of a melody long after the music stopped.

Now, it was her turn to listen.

Meditate. Breathe. Reach.

Mami’s breathing deepened as she extended her awareness outward. In her mind’s eye, she imagined a slow descent—falling softly through layers of consciousness—until her senses began to blur and shift. She reached toward the life within the lake.

At first, it was difficult. Aquatic life moved differently than what she had known on land. Slower, yes, but also more... fluid. Alien. Elusive.

Still, she pressed on.

Her first connection came with the waterlilies. Their petals drifted gently above the surface, their roots anchored in the mud below. But as Mami connected with them—*truly* connected—she felt something astonishing.

They were silent sentinels, but not empty. Their lives were filled with rhythm. Rising with the sun, closing with the moon. Breathing through stillness. A soft pulse of life, steady and calm. They existed in quiet grace, unbothered by the ripples of the world around them.

Mami inhaled sharply, her heart aching at the beauty of it.

This... this is a simple plant. And yet it holds such grace, such still purpose.

It reminded her of her earlier connection with the grove's wildflower, but this—this felt deeper, richer. Like understanding a poem written in a language she never knew she spoke.

And then her attention was drawn to the lotuses.

Unlike the waterlilies, the lotuses stood taller—rising further above the surface, their blossoms bold and elegant. As Mami focused on them, a different feeling came over her. There was strength there. Not defiance, but resilience. These flowers grew from the same murky waters, but reached high with delicate pride, unsoiled by what birthed them.

They pulsed with slow, ancient confidence.

She felt their cycles, too—the way their blooms opened with patience, not urgency. As if they understood time better than she did. There was something spiritual about them, as if every petal was shaped by memory.

They are not just surviving. They are transcending, she realized.

So this is what Lunaria meant...

The contrast between the waterlilies and the lotuses struck her. One expressed peace, the other quiet power. Yet both belonged to the same water, both taught without speaking.

Finally, she turned her senses toward the fish beneath the surface.

They moved like flickering thoughts—darting, shimmering, elusive. At first, the sensation was overwhelming. Mami could feel their skittish energy, the way they responded to every ripple, every shadow. They pulsed with raw instinct: hunger, caution, curiosity, alertness. Dozens of lives brushing past one another without a single word.

But then... she noticed something more.

They weren't panicked. They weren't lost. They flowed *with* the world around them, not apart from it. They wove through the water like dancers in a silent ballet—each one aware of the current, the pressure, the presence of others.

They accept the unknown. They don't resist it. They live inside it.

And for the first time, Mami didn't just understand their movement—she admired it.

A deep calm settled in her chest. She had come seeking clarity, guidance... something to control. But instead, she found life in its rawest, most present form. It didn't need to be controlled. It needed to be *felt*.

It was overwhelming.

This is life too... It's just hidden below the surface. Quiet, but constant.

Tears welled in her eyes—not from sadness, but from awe.

The world beneath the lake was so alive, so intricate, and she had never truly noticed it before. As a magical girl who soared through battles with rifles and ribbons, she'd always fought above the surface. Now she was discovering an entirely new layer of life.

And it was beautiful.

She slowly opened her eyes, letting the connection fade. The lake sparkled before her, unchanged... and yet, it felt entirely different now.

A quiet smile formed on Mami's lips.

"I never knew," she whispered.

Beside her, Lunaria remained still, her eyes still closed, but the faintest curve of a smile appeared on her face.

The meditation had ended in silence, but it was not an empty silence.

As Mami and Lunaria rose from their seated positions by the lake, the wind rustled gently through the trees, as if nature itself was bowing in respect to their stillness.

They began their slow walk back toward the cabin, feet brushing softly against the path of moss and stone. The light filtering through the trees had grown warmer—late afternoon sun casting long, golden rays.

Lunaria was the first to speak, her tone as calm and measured as always.

"Mami... what did you learn today?"

Mami took a long breath, her gaze drifting to the rustling treetops, though her mind lingered far behind—back to the water's edge, and even further, to the tranquil grove where it had all begun.

"It's... hard to describe," she began slowly. "Back in the grove, when you first explained *connect* to me, I didn't really understand. I thought I did—I thought it was some kind of focus exercise, a new type of meditation. But then, when I tried... I felt something. I was close. Almost grasping the essence of the plants around me."

Her voice lowered with a hint of awe. "I focused on one flower. Just one. I blocked everything else out. And for the briefest moment, I felt it. Its rhythm. Its warmth. Its presence. It was so simple, and yet... it moved me."

She shook her head lightly, still marveling. "I never knew that kind of connection was even possible. To truly sense something without trying to control it or fight it. Just being there with it. Letting it be."

She paused again, then added, her tone quieter, more introspective. "And then... a bee landed on that very flower. Just going about its day, gathering pollen. At first, I was startled—I mean, it was so close—but then I tried connecting with it too."

Her gaze drifted slightly skyward, as though replaying the moment. “It wasn’t just movement or instinct. There was... purpose in it. Hunger, yes—but also diligence. Focus. A rhythm to its flight, to how it searched, how it worked. It wasn’t chaotic. It was... harmonious. I could feel how important that little creature was to the entire cycle of life around it.”

Mami let out a breath that was almost a laugh, faint and amazed. “It made me feel small. But not in a bad way. Just... humble. Like I was beginning to see the threads tying everything together. I’ve fought for so long, always thinking of life in terms of conflict, survival, duty... I never took the time to see how much beauty there is in just *being alive*.”

She glanced back at Lunaria with a newfound light behind her eyes.

“This power... this idea of *connect*... it’s not about strength. It’s about understanding. And I think, maybe for the first time in a long time, I’m starting to really understand.”

Mami then glanced back toward the lake behind them as the memory deepened.

“And then today... with the lake. The waterlilies, the lotus flowers, the fish... I never gave aquatic life much thought, honestly. It always felt distant. Quiet. Unreachable.”

She paused, her expression thoughtful. “But when I reached out with that same sense of focus... it opened up. The waterlilies were like living chandeliers—rooted and serene, but quietly expressive. They didn’t speak in the way I expected. It was more like... they breathed light. They were gentle, almost meditative. Content just to float, to soak in the sun, to exist.”

Mami's eyes drifted half-closed, as though she were still feeling the cool air by the lakeside. “And the lotus flowers... there was something ancient in them. Like they were carrying quiet wisdom. I could feel their cycles—blooming, closing, sinking, rising. They’ve done this forever. It was strangely comforting.”

She smiled faintly, eyes glowing with remembered wonder. “And the fish... they moved like thoughts. Fast and fleeting and full of feeling. It was like watching dozens of little emotions darting just beneath the surface. At first, it was overwhelming. So many signals, so much instinct... hunger, fear, curiosity. They felt everything in sharp flashes. But then I realized... they weren’t scattered. They were *fluid*. They moved *with* the world, not against it.”

She gave a quiet laugh. “They didn’t try to change the current—they let it carry them, and found their way through it. There was beauty in that. A kind of wisdom I never considered.”

Mami drew a slow breath, then looked down at her hands. “I never thought I’d learn something from fish. But they made me realize... maybe not everything needs to be grasped or controlled. Maybe some things just want to be felt. Understood.”

She fell silent for a moment, the breeze gently teasing her golden hair as she looked down at her hands.

“In both places, I felt something I’ve never really felt before—respect. Not just for nature, but for life itself. For how everything has a role, a rhythm, a purpose. I don’t think I ever saw it that clearly before.”

Her eyes lifted to Lunaria.

“Maybe that’s why you and Kasumi seem so at peace when you’re out there, just walking among trees or foraging by the riverside. You’re not just looking—you’re listening. Not just gathering—you’re connecting. And now, after today, I think I’m beginning to understand what that really means.”

Lunaria looked at her with a gentle smile—the kind that held more meaning than a dozen spoken compliments. “You’re making good progress.”

She paused, eyes drifting toward the lake, where the last rays of sunlight shimmered on the surface like drifting glass. Her voice was calm, but carried the quiet weight of deep reflection.

“*Connect* is more than just sensing things. It’s about listening—*truly* listening—not just to others, but to yourself. It’s about resonating. About recognizing that everything, even the smallest life, has a voice... and learning how to meet that voice with your own.”

Mami stayed silent, hanging onto every word.

Lunaria’s gaze returned to her, steady and kind.

“This is why *Connect* between magical girls is so powerful. When two hearts understand one another—when there’s trust, empathy, vulnerability—the link becomes something sacred. Strong. Protective. But when that understanding is missing... when one side resists... the link weakens. Sometimes it fails entirely.”

Her expression softened as she continued.

“It’s not easy. Magical girls carry so many burdens. They’re closed off. Guarded. Hurt. And who could blame them?”

She stepped gently along the grassy trail, her hands loosely folded behind her. “But the more you open your heart—to others, to the world, to *yourself*—the stronger your *Connect* will grow. And the more peace you’ll carry with you.”

She slowed her steps, then stopped, facing Mami with warmth in her eyes.

“Mami... life is beautiful. Not because it’s perfect or painless, but because it’s *alive*. Its value doesn’t lie in power or achievements, but in the quiet moments. The living, breathing ones. Every breath, every thought, every bond you form... it’s all a small miracle. It’s a form of magic.”

She tilted her head gently.

“That beauty doesn’t vanish just because you became a magical girl. If anything, you see it more clearly—because you’ve faced the darkness too.”

A beat passed, soft and meaningful.

“I hope one day you’ll come to see *your* life as something beautiful. Not just because of what you’ve

done, or how strong you are—but because you’re still here. You’re still living it. And even in a world full of Witches, struggles, and responsibilities... you can still live with joy.”

She reached out and lightly touched Mami’s shoulder.

“You don’t have to earn joy, Mami. You’re allowed to feel it. Just as you are.”

Mami stopped walking for a moment.

Lunaria’s hand rested lightly on her shoulder, but the weight of her words lingered far deeper.

She turned slowly, golden eyes wide—not with confusion, but with something raw and quietly unraveling. Gratitude, wonder... and beneath that, something much older: a longing she hadn’t let herself fully name.

“...Thank you,” Mami whispered. Her voice was soft, nearly swallowed by the lake breeze. “I don’t know if I deserve that kind of peace yet. But... I’d like to.”

Her gaze dropped slightly, lost in thought.

“I was just a girl when I made my wish,” she said after a beat. “My parents... we were in a car accident. I remember the glass. The silence afterward. I was so scared. I didn’t even think. I just wished to survive.”

Her hand hovered near her chest, as though feeling for something that wasn’t there.

“I didn’t become a magical girl to protect anyone. Or to help. I just didn’t want to die.”

She let the words hang, honest and unvarnished.

“Since then, I’ve been alone more often than not. Fighting. Struggling. Coping. I told myself I had to be strong. Had to be reliable. Had to be worthy of the life I’d wished for. But even then... I kept wondering what it was all for. If there was a point. If I had any real worth outside of what I could do for others.”

Her voice faltered slightly, but she didn’t look away.

“I’ve spent so much time thinking joy was something I had to earn. Something I didn’t have a right to unless I proved myself first.”

She looked up at Lunaria again, eyes glistening but steady.

“So hearing you say that... that I don’t have to earn joy... that I’m allowed to feel it, just as I am...”

A single breath left her lips, trembling at the edge of release.

“It means more than I can say.”

Lunaria smiled and nodded, her voice as soft as the coming twilight. “Yes. Everyone has the right to happiness. And you can choose to live... with joy in your heart.”

They continued walking, side by side, the quiet forest gradually thinning as the familiar clearing came into view. The soft scent of herbs and woodsmoke drifted on the breeze, carrying with it the promise of rest.

“And speaking of being joyful...” Lunaria said, her lips curving into a knowing smile.

“Welcome back, travelers from the land of the lake~!”

Kasumi popped out from behind the herb shed like a jack-in-the-box, hands on her hips, grinning from ear to ear. “Dinner prep is underway, and I found some fresh mushrooms near the hillside. Don’t worry—I already did the poison test!”

Mami blinked at the sudden burst of energy, then let out a quiet, genuine laugh. “Kasumi...”

Lunaria greeted her with a fond shake of her head. “You’re always full of surprises.”

“Come on in! We’ve got stories to swap, don’t we?” Kasumi beamed, already bouncing toward the cabin. “You both look like you had some deep ‘life revelations’ or something~!”

Lunaria glanced at Mami, who gave a soft nod, her heart still holding the echoes of their walk.

“Yes,” Mami murmured, voice calm and steady. “Something like that.”

And with that, the three of them stepped into the warmth of the wooden cabin—where firelight flickered, supper simmered, and companionship waited at the end of the day’s discoveries.

Chapter 6 – The Essence of Creation

Dinner was nearly ready, the cabin filled with the sweet smells of roasting vegetables and herbs, mixed with the earthy scent of the forest outside. Kasumi had practically bounced into the cabin, full of energy, already taking the first bite of a dish she had "claimed" for herself from the table.

“So, Mami,” Kasumi asked between bites, grinning, “What did you do for training today? Get any breakthroughs?”

Mami set down her fork, her thoughts gently swirling through the day’s experiences. There was a calmness within her that hadn’t been there before. She looked toward Lunaria, her voice soft but filled with new understanding. “We focused on ‘connect’ today,” Mami began, her gaze thoughtful. “Lunaria explained that connect is not just about magical girls syncing their magic. Its core is about sensing things, and more importantly, about listening—not just to others, but to yourself as well. It’s about resonating with life, recognizing that everything has a voice, no matter how small.”

She paused for a moment, letting the concept sink in again. "It's about meeting that voice with your own, and creating a bridge between them. That's the magic—when two energies meet and become something greater than the sum of their parts."

Her voice softened further, reflecting the quiet realization of something profound. "At first, I thought it was all about controlling magic, making things happen, forcing life to bend to my will. But now... now I understand that it's more than that. It's about harmony. About listening to what's already there and letting it guide you."

Mami looked out the window, as if recalling the moments from earlier that day. "When I meditated in the grove, I started with the plants. I connected with the wildflowers and the trees, just as Lunaria said. I focused, really focused on one flower, and... it was like I could feel its pulse. Its rhythm. It was a quiet kind of life, but it was full of purpose—just rising with the sun, closing with the moon. It was alive, but in a way I had never felt before. It wasn't just about what the flower could do. It was about understanding its stillness. Its presence."

She paused, a soft smile tugging at her lips as she continued, her voice more animated now. "And then, after that, I turned my attention to something else—something smaller. A bee, gathering pollen from the flower. I focused on its movements, how it hovered so deliberately, how it darted from flower to flower, collecting life's essence. It was like... I became the bee for a moment. The rhythm of its flight, the way it interacted with the world—there was an energy to it, but it was different. Faster. Livelier. And still, it was part of something bigger. It wasn't about the bee's speed or the pollen it collected—it was about the connection. The way it all flowed together."

Mami looked back at Lunaria, a newfound sense of clarity in her eyes. "It's amazing. I never realized how much magic and life are interconnected. How everything, even the smallest things, has its own energy—its own presence. I think... I think I really understand now. I'd never realized how much beauty there was in just being. How much we miss when we're too busy to stop and really look."

Mami paused again, remembering the serenity of the grove and the calm pulse of the plants and animals. She then continued, her tone shifting slightly with the next memory. "Then we moved to the lake. Lunaria took me through the process of connecting with aquatic life. I've never really thought about water, or the life within it, in the same way as the land. I guess I always thought of the lake as something distant—something cool and untouched. But when I started to connect with the fish and the waterlilies, everything changed."

She smiled faintly, her voice filled with the wonder of the experience. "The waterlilies were like living chandeliers. They floated so gracefully, their roots grounded beneath the water, yet their petals swayed freely with the currents. They were silent, but not empty. There was a quiet, steady rhythm to them—something beautiful in their stillness. It was like they were breathing in time with the water, part of the lake itself."

Mami's eyes shone, her excitement contagious as she recalled the next step in her journey. "And the fish—oh, the fish! They moved so quickly, like flashes of thoughts in a crowded room, darting this way and that. Their lives were full of fleeting emotions, signals passed through the water. It was

overwhelming at first, feeling so much at once. But it was also beautiful. I could feel their urgency, their freedom. The lake came alive in ways I never imagined."

She leaned back slightly, her expression more thoughtful now, as if she were processing the magnitude of what she had experienced. "It was similar with the grove, but different. The beauty of the lake was in motion—quick and fluid. It was about the constant flow, the rhythm of life in the water. It was so much more than I thought. I had no idea there was this much life and magic in something I've always taken for granted."

Mami paused again, her voice quieter now, as if contemplating the depth of the lesson. "When I look back at the grove and the lake, it's like I've been blind my whole life. I saw the forest and water as things in the background, but now I realize they're part of something bigger. The way life pulses, how everything is interconnected—it's not about controlling magic, it's about connecting with it. Understanding it. Feeling it."

She looked down at her hands, a smile touching her lips. "It's like... I've learned to see life and magic in a completely different way. It's not about power. It's about resonance. The more I connect—whether with the plants, the animals, or myself—the more I can understand, and the more peace I feel."

Mami looked back up at Lunaria, her heart lighter than before. "I never realized how much beauty there is in the world, in the life around us. It's not just about magic. It's about seeing the wonder in everything. And now I understand why you and Kasumi are always so at peace when you're with nature. It's not just about the plants and the animals—it's about the connection, the understanding. It's about living in harmony with the world around you."

Mami's eyes then lowered a bit and softened, "And I also learned to appreciate the beauty in all life, including mine. I should try to live life with joy, even when I am facing struggles and responsibilities."

Lunaria's gaze softened, a smile spreading across her face. "You're learning more than just magic, Mami. You're learning to live with it, to embrace it, and to share that understanding with others. That's true strength."

Lunaria, smiled and looked at Kasumi. "Mami also learned how to get the essence of plant life today by connecting with them. She was able to feel the plants, understand their purpose in the world."

At that, Kasumi's face lit up even more, her eyes gleaming with genuine curiosity. "Wait, really? You mean, you can actually create something from the essence of a plant? That's incredible! Can you show me?"

Mami hesitated, looking at Lunaria nervously. She wasn't quite sure how well she could replicate the connection yet, or if it would even work in front of everyone. But Lunaria, who had been watching her, gave her a reassuring smile and a nod.

"Go ahead, Mami," Lunaria said gently. "You've made great progress. I believe in you."

Mami took a deep breath, her thoughts steadying as she closed her eyes. She inwardly focused on the essence she had gathered earlier in the grove. The quiet pulse of life she felt in the plants—the wildflowers, the herbs—those energies, those rhythms were still fresh in her mind.

She put all her efforts focusing on the essence one of those plants that she stored in her soulgem, as if the connection between her and the plant were still alive and resonating. She thought about the herb she had connected with—a simple, earthy plant, full of quiet purpose.

Slowly, she focused deeper, drawing on the essence, concentrating on the rhythmic life of the plant. She tried to let the plant's essence flow through her—letting its energy become part of her own.

For a moment, the air around her seemed to thicken with intent. Nothing happened at first.

Then a faint glow sparked beneath her fingertips, like a spark catching a dry thread. Her eyes narrowed with determination as she held her breath, focusing even further.

This time, the glow deepened. The herb's rhythm—its steady pulse of life—was clearer, more tangible in her mind. She could feel it, like a heartbeat, like a small presence in the world, just as Lunaria had described.

Mami's hands trembled slightly as the outline of a leaf began to form between her fingers. It flickered at first, but this time, it stayed. The leaf shimmered with a vibrant green glow, delicate and full of life, though still faint.

Kasumi, who had been watching with wide-eyed interest, clapped her hands lightly. "Ooooh, close! You almost got it! That was really cool!"

Mami tried again, this time focusing even more intently. Sweat beaded on her forehead, and her hands shook slightly with concentration, but she could feel the rhythm of the leaf in her mind, the pulse of its essence growing more tangible.

With a final push, she focused, letting the rhythm guide her. Slowly, the leaf solidified in her hands—small, delicate, yet unmistakably real. It wasn't perfect, but it was there. The green shimmered in the light as it caught her gaze, full of potential.

Mami exhaled sharply, her eyes wide with astonishment and joy. "I... I did it!" she whispered, her heart racing with excitement.

Lunaria clapped softly, a proud smile spreading across her face. "Well done, Mami. That was incredible." Her voice was warm and sincere. "You've come so far."

Kasumi grinned from ear to ear. "That's amazing! You're full of surprises, Mami!" She stood up dramatically, hands on her hips as she took a bow. "A round of applause for our talented adventurer! Who knew you'd have such hidden skills?"

Mami's cheeks flushed, a small laugh escaping her as she looked at the tiny leaf in her hand. She couldn't help the bright smile that spread across her face. "I... I really didn't think I could do that. It was harder than I thought, but... it felt so good when it finally worked."

"You're learning to connect with more than just nature," Lunaria added, her voice gentle. "You're learning the essence of creation itself, Mami. That's a beautiful thing."

Mami nodded, her eyes still bright with the sense of accomplishment. "Thank you, Lunaria. And Kasumi, I guess I'm not as hopeless as I thought!"

Kasumi gave her an exaggerated wink. "Hopeless? Pfft, no way. You're a natural! Soon enough, you'll be creating whole gardens with that magic of yours!"

Mami looked at the tiny leaf in her hand again, a sense of wonder settling in her heart. She felt like she was truly beginning to understand the rhythm of life—how everything, from the smallest plant to the largest creature, resonated with its own unique purpose.

And maybe, just maybe, she was starting to feel a little more at peace with her own place in that rhythm.

"Thank you both," Mami said, her voice soft. "I couldn't have done this without your help."

"Of course," Lunaria replied, her smile radiant. "You're the one who did the work. You've earned this."

As they sat down together at the table, the evening began to settle in around them. The warmth of the cabin, the flicker of the fire, and the soft hum of nature outside made everything feel... right. For the first time in a long while, Mami felt something stir quietly in her heart—acceptance. Not just of her magic, but of herself.

And, perhaps more importantly, joy.

Chapter 6b: Mysteries of Kamihama

As they continued their meal, the warm atmosphere of the cabin lingering like a blanket around them, Mami turned her attention to Kasumi.

"So," she asked, her curiosity piqued, "how did your exploration of Kamihama go?"

Kasumi looked up from her plate, her grin immediate and bright. "Oh, very interesting! That city's a whole maze of secrets and weirdness—and not just the labyrinths."

Mami tilted her head. "Weird how?"

"Well," Kasumi began, twirling her chopsticks between her fingers, "there's a group there called the *Wings of the Magius*. They're trying to bring 'salvation' to all magical girls. Big mission statement, right?" She glanced between Mami and Lunaria. "Apparently, their leaders—Touka, Nemu, and some bizarre artist named Alina—created something called the *Automatic Purification System*. APS for short."

Mami frowned slightly. “Purification...?”

Kasumi nodded. “Yeah. The system spans all of Kamihama. It kicks in right before a magical girl turns into a witch. Instead of transforming, she... becomes a *doppel*.” She gestured vaguely in the air, as if to sketch its oddity. “It kind of *looks* like a witch, but the girl stays in control—well, mostly. And once the doppel fades, she’s back to normal. Soul gem purified.”

Lunaria’s expression turned thoughtful. “That’s... remarkable. If it truly works that way, it could prevent a great deal of tragedy.”

Kasumi shrugged. “That’s the idea. But not everyone’s on board with it. One of the group’s founders, Mifuyu, used to be really close with Yachiyo—they lived together at one point, I think—but things between them are... tense now. Yachiyo doesn’t trust the Wings of the Magius. She seems convinced they’re hiding something.”

“Do you think they are?” Mami asked quietly.

“I don’t know for sure, but I believe they are,” Kasumi replied, voice lowering slightly. “They *say* their goal is to save magical girls, but something about it feels... complicated. Maybe even dangerous.”

Mami glanced at her, intrigued by the shift in tone. “You think they’re hiding something?”

Kasumi nodded slowly, then leaned her arms on the table. “There’s just this *feeling*, you know? Like there’s something bigger going on behind the scenes. I talked to some of the girls working with them—and they believe in the cause, don’t get me wrong—but there’s a strange pressure there. Like they’ve convinced themselves this is the *only* way to survive.”

Lunaria’s eyes narrowed slightly in thought. “Desperation can justify many things... even the wrong ones.”

“Exactly,” Kasumi said, snapping her fingers. “And then there’s Mitama Yakumo.”

Mami blinked. “The coordinator, right?”

“Yep! Magical girl coordinator of Kamihama,” Kasumi confirmed, sitting upright with a grin. “She offers all sorts of services for magical girls—healing, support, advice... But the big one? Adjustments.”

“Adjustments?” Mami asked, her expression tightening.

“She can... alter your soul gem,” Kasumi explained, gesturing in the air like she was sketching invisible symbols. “Basically, she syncs it with the APS. That’s what makes the doppel system work across the city. She’s the one enabling it for the Wings of the Magius.”

Mami’s brow furrowed deeply. “That sounds... risky. Do the magical girls know that’s what she’s doing?”

Kasumi shook her head slowly. “Nope. Not really. They think the adjustments are just to make their magic more stable or efficient. I don’t think most of them realize it links them directly to the APS. Or that it’s what allows them to use a doppel in the first place.”

Mami’s eyes widened slightly, her concern growing. “So Mitama is the one creating all the doppels?”

“She doesn’t manifest them herself,” Kasumi clarified. “But she’s the one making them *possible*. She’s scaling the system—tuning girls like instruments until they sync with the city’s magic flow. It’s brilliant, honestly. And kind of terrifying.”

Mami glanced down at her plate, her appetite dimming beneath the weight of that realization. “I don’t know if I could trust something like that,” she said quietly. “It sounds too good to be true... kind of like Kyubey’s contract did.”

She looked up again, her eyes calm but clear. “Back then, I didn’t ask enough questions. I just wanted hope—and power. But I’ve learned that if something promises to fix everything without a cost... then the cost is probably just hidden.”

Kasumi grinned and pointed her chopsticks at Mami. “Now that’s what I’m talking about! Mami’s not falling for any sweet-sounding traps anymore!”

Lunaria’s smile was gentle, her voice warm. “You’ve come a long way. Not just in magic, but in spirit. The way you see things... it’s changed.”

Kasumi leaned back and added, more seriously now, “Mitama is very good at making people trust her. Charming, thoughtful, insightful. But when I met her... I could tell she was trying to read me.”

Lunaria tilted her head, “She suspected something?”

“Oh, for sure,” Kasumi said, her tone light but her eyes sharp. “She ran a few passive tests, asked questions that didn’t sound like questions. She wanted to figure out if I was a magical girl or not.”

Lunaria watched her quietly, the corners of her mouth lifting in a subtle smile.

Mami leaned in slightly, curious. “And what did she find?”

Kasumi’s grin widened as she popped another bite of food into her mouth. “She didn’t.”

Mami let out a quiet laugh, shaking her head. “Of course she didn’t.”

“I might’ve confused her on purpose,” Kasumi added with a wink. “Just a little. She’s sharp, but she’s not used to dealing with people like me.”

“You mean enigmas?” Mami teased lightly.

“Exactly,” Kasumi said proudly, raising her glass. “To mysteries.”

Lunaria lifted her own cup with a soft chuckle. “To mysteries—and those who guard them well.”

The three of them clinked their cups together, the moment warm and full of quiet camaraderie, the firelight dancing across their faces as the evening continued.

Chapter 7 – Echoes of Memory

After the last bite of dinner had been savored and the warmth of the meal settled into them, Kasumi pushed herself up from her seat with a stretch and a bright smile.

"Alright, time to show you two what I saw today," she announced. "Let's head to the arena. I think you'll want to see it for yourselves."

Lunaria and Mami followed her outside, the cool forest air brushing gently against their skin as they made their way through the glade toward the arena. The night was quiet, stars glittering above like distant soul gems. Soon they arrived at the familiar circular chamber—lush, soft petals opening in the center like a blossoming flower, inviting them into the arena's flower pods.

As the three settled into the cushioned seats, the walls shimmered to life, responding to Kasumi's thoughts and intent. A soft hum vibrated through the floor as projection magic began to take shape.

Kasumi turned to them with a grin. “At the Memory Museum in Kamihama, I got to walk through memories—real ones. Mifuyu's... and even Yachiyo's. It was like reliving their past. Pretty impressive that magical girls managed to set something like that up.”

The projection began.

It showed Kasumi's entrance into the Memory Museum, her encounter with Mifuyu Azusa, and the shared memories that unfolded—Mifuyu and Yachiyo's days as partners, their bond, and the eventual strain brought on by the secrets of the magical girl system. It was raw, human, and quietly tragic.

Mami's hands folded in her lap as she watched. Her eyes were locked on the image of Yachiyo's pained expression—so familiar, so much like her own during those difficult days of disillusionment. “They learned everything,” she whispered. “Just like I did...”

The memory continued. Kasumi's meeting with Kuroe and Mitama followed—their conversation about the Automatic Purification System and the strange, eerie emergence of the doppel. The scene where a magical girl transformed into a doppel played before them—dark, chaotic, strange—and then faded as the girl returned to her normal self, soul gem cleansed.

Mami's breath caught. “That's... it actually works.”

Lunaria leaned forward slightly, watching with curiosity as the projection played out. “It's impressive,” she murmured. “They didn't fall apart after learning the truth. They tried to fix it—together. That takes strength.”

The image of the APS, the giant network that covered Kamihama with invisible protection, flickered across the arena like a web of magic and hope.

“But,” Lunaria added thoughtfully, “the more I see it, the more it feels... brittle. If it falters, everything will collapse. If the doppel loses control, or the system malfunctions...”

Kasumi nodded slowly. “I’ve been thinking the same thing. It’s clever, and I respect what they’re trying to do. But something about it feels like a ticking time bomb.”

The projection dimmed and faded, the arena growing still once more.

Mami sat in silence for a long moment, then spoke, her voice quiet and trembling with conflicted emotion. “The APS and the doppel system... it’s incredible. If it really purifies soul gems... if it truly saves magical girls from becoming witches, then maybe...”

She looked at Lunaria and Kasumi, her golden eyes wide with a flicker of hope. “Maybe Sayaka, Kyoko, and Homura should come to Kamihama. Maybe they could be saved.”

A light shone in her expression—hesitant but radiant, like the first dawn after a long storm. “It’s so similar to what I’m learning now—managing emotions, finding control, creating disconnection. But the system... it does it all at once. It makes salvation feel... easy.”

Lunaria’s expression turned serious, but gentle. “That’s the illusion, Mami. It may appear effortless, but it skips the journey you’ve been walking. You’re learning the essence of magic itself—the emotional roots, the balance of give and take, the true art of connect. You understand what’s happening inside you.”

She gestured softly. “Those girls using the APS... they don’t seem to understand their own transformations. The doppel isn’t truly theirs. They can’t call it when they want. They don’t control it—it controls them.”

Mami lowered her eyes, nodding slowly.

Lunaria’s voice remained calm but firm. “You’ve been burned once by rushing into something that promised power without understanding. Don’t let that happen again, even if it looks like salvation.”

Kasumi leaned back with a thoughtful frown, then added, “I agree. Power without understanding isn’t really yours—there are usually strings attached, and it might come back to bite you. You shouldn’t trust anything unless it’s something you truly understand and can control. Or unless it’s a gift—offered freely, from someone you trust.”

Mami considered their words in silence, eyes drifting to her hands, the same ones that had just created a fragile, glowing leaf from pure magical essence. That had been slow. Earned. Real.

“...You’re right,” she said at last, voice quiet but steady. “I rushed once. I let my need for answers and salvation blind me. This time... I’ll be careful. I’ll keep learning. And if there really is a way to save others—Sayaka, Kyoko, Homura—I want it to be a way we can trust. A way we understand. A way that won’t turn into another trap.”

She looked up at them again, her face calm but full of resolve. “I want to earn that kind of power. Not just be given it. If salvation exists, then I want to walk toward it—not be pushed into it.”

Lunaria’s smile returned, warm and full of pride. “Then you’re on the right path, Mami.”

Kasumi gave her a wink and a playful elbow bump. “See? Told you you’re getting stronger.”

Mami let herself smile. The doubts weren’t gone—but now, they were accompanied by something stronger.

Clarity.

And choice.

Lunaria glanced toward the center of the arena, where the shimmering floor had dimmed once more. She raised her hand gently, and with a subtle gesture, a new projection began to bloom—this one tinged with a heavier, colder light.

"Mami," Lunaria said softly, "there’s more you should see. About your friends."

Mami straightened in her seat as the image formed.

A familiar highway bridge appeared—lonely and quiet beneath a cloud-streaked sky. The air in the scene was heavy with tension. On one side stood **Kyoko**, red spear gripped tightly, her expression set in frustration. On the other stood **Sayaka**, sword in hand, eyes shadowed with self-righteous anger. Between them, standing further back, was **Homura**, arms folded, gaze unreadable.

Mami’s heart sank.

“They’re still fighting...” she whispered, her voice aching with pain. “Why can’t they support each other instead?”

The argument between Sayaka and Kyoko played out silently in the arena’s projection, but **Mami could feel the tension bleeding through the images**, sharp and bitter like a blade pressed to the skin. Even though she was watching from afar, the emotions were unmistakable—**frustration, heartbreak, pride, and pain** all crashing into each other like waves.

Then, before the clash could begin, **another figure ran into the scene**—a blur of pink and panic.

Madoka.

Breathless, desperate, eyes wide with fear, she surged forward between the two girls. In a sudden, instinctive motion, **she grabbed Sayaka’s Soul Gem and hurled it over the edge of the bridge.**

“**Please stop... This isn’t right...**” Madoka cried out, tears spilling from her eyes.

Gasps echoed in the arena chamber.

“**Madoka...**” Mami whispered, voice cracking in disbelief.

Before anyone could move, **Homura flinched**, her eyes flashing in alarm. Her composure cracked—**she grimaced sharply, muttering, “You idiot—” before vaulting off the edge of the bridge.**

Mami's breath caught. She sat forward, **gripping the edge of her seat**, eyes wide.

“That wasn’t cold,” she murmured. **“That was instinct... she cared.”**

Her gaze lingered on the projection, voice softening further.

“And she knows...”

Lunaria glanced at Mami but said nothing—watching her student draw her own conclusions.

In the projection, **Sayaka suddenly collapsed**, her body going limp like a marionette with its strings cut.

“Sayaka!” Madoka screamed, her voice cracking with panic as she rushed forward, her footsteps echoing against the pavement.

Kyoko was faster. She darted to Sayaka’s side and caught her just before she hit the ground, lowering her gently. **“Hey! Sayaka! Don’t screw around like that—wake up!”** she shouted, shaking her by the shoulders. **“Come on, say something!”**

But Sayaka didn’t move. Her eyes were vacant. Her limbs hung uselessly.

“What the hell is this?!” Kyoko barked, desperation rising in her voice. **“She’s not breathing—what did you do?!”**

Madoka dropped to her knees beside them, tears spilling down her cheeks. **“I—I didn’t know this would happen! I just wanted to stop the fight!** I thought if I got rid of her Soul Gem, she’d stop!” She clutched her hands to her chest. **“I didn’t mean to hurt her!”**

Mami watched the scene unfold from her seat in the arena, heart twisting at the raw, gut-wrenching panic on her friends’ faces.

And then—

Kyubey stepped into the scene, eyes unblinking, tail swaying gently behind him.

“There's no need for alarm,” he said coolly. “She’s not dead. That body is just a shell. It can’t function if the Soul Gem is too far away.”

He turned his gaze toward Madoka. “You see, the Soul Gem contains the magical girl’s soul. That’s what you exchanged when you made the contract.”

Madoka stared at him, trembling. **“W-What? Her... soul?”**

Kyoko's mouth parted, eyes going wide. "**You mean—she's not even in her body anymore? That's what this is?!**"

"Correct," Kyubey said matter-of-factly. "Her soul resides in the gem. Her body is merely a vessel—an organic puppet that receives commands within a hundred-meter range. Any farther, and..." He motioned casually to Sayaka's limp form. "This is the result."

The truth landed like a blade.

Kyubey's words hung in the air, cold and clinical, yet earth-shattering in their implication.

Mami sat frozen, her gaze fixed on the projection, her face unreadable. Then, slowly, she released a quiet breath, her shoulders sinking ever so slightly.

"Just like the girls in Kamihama," she murmured. "Mifuyu, Yachiyo... all the others at the Memory Museum. It's happening again. Everyone's learning the truth the hard way."

Lunaria placed a gentle hand on her shoulder, grounding her as the weight of old and new wounds mixed inside her chest.

In the projection, the silence was deafening.

Madoka's knees buckled. She fell back onto the pavement, her hands trembling as she stared at Sayaka's lifeless body. Her lips moved, but no words came out. Only the quiet sound of her shallow, frantic breathing.

Kyoko's legs gave out as well. She dropped beside Madoka, fists clenched against the ground, her whole body shaking.

Their expressions were mirrors of **complete devastation**—wide, disbelieving eyes, lips parted in shock, tears threatening to fall but somehow frozen in place. Like the truth had cracked something inside them they weren't ready to face.

They couldn't speak. Couldn't move. Just **shattered silence**, echoing louder than any scream.

"But they don't know everything yet," Mami continued, her voice soft and tinged with sadness. "Not like the girls in Kamihama. Not about witches."

In the projection, **Homura returned**, drenched from the river, panting quietly as she approached. Her hair clung to her face and neck, and water dripped from her clothes, but her grip was firm—she held Sayaka's Soul Gem as if it were something fragile and sacred.

Without saying a word, she kneeled beside Sayaka's body and gently placed the gem into her palm.

A moment passed.

Then Sayaka's body jolted—her chest rising sharply as if she were taking her first breath again. Her eyes fluttered open, unfocused at first, then gradually sharpening.

“Wh-what...?” she breathed, sitting up slowly. She looked around, disoriented.

Her gaze fell on Madoka and Kyoko, both still as statues, their faces twisted in open, silent horror.

“Madoka? Kyoko?” Sayaka leaned closer. “Hey... what’s wrong?”

Neither of them responded.

Sayaka waved her hand in front of Madoka's face, then Kyoko's. Still nothing. She gave Kyoko's shoulder a small shake, then a firmer one.

“Hey! What’s going on? What happened?!”

But both girls remained motionless—trapped in their own stunned disbelief, as if the truth had pulled their minds away from the moment and left only the shells behind.

Sayaka's face twisted in confusion, and then frustration. Her heart thudded in her chest, unease rising like bile.

A quiet voice behind her made her flinch.

“You died,” said Homura, standing tall now, her expression blank and cold. “Or, more precisely—your body stopped functioning when your Soul Gem left the area. That’s where your soul is now. In that gem.”

Sayaka whipped around, eyes narrowing when she saw who it was.

“You again?” she spat, voice sharp with contempt. “Why are you even here?”

Homura's eyes didn't flicker. She stood still, soaked and expressionless, staring at Sayaka as though looking through her.

Sayaka's fists clenched.

Homura's face remained a mask of icy detachment—cold, unreadable, almost inhuman. Her gaze locked onto Sayaka's eyes with an intensity that sent a chill down the spine, as if every ounce of warmth had been stripped away.

“Madoka threw your Soul Gem off the bridge,” Homura said, her voice flat, devoid of any softness. “She thought it would stop the fight. She didn't understand... it's literally your soul. Without it, your body is nothing. Just an empty shell.”

Sayaka's eyes snapped wide open, terror flooding through her like a sudden storm. Her legs gave way, and she collapsed onto her knees, trembling uncontrollably.

“No... No... that can’t be true...” she whispered, voice cracking under the weight of the revelation. “This has to be a nightmare... a bad dream...” Her whole body shook, as if trying to reject the crushing truth.

Homura’s gaze didn’t waver. She turned away without another word.

“I warned you,” she said coldly, beginning to walk away. “I told you not to become a magical girl. You didn’t listen.”

Her words landed like heavy stones, cold and merciless.

Kyoko, her breath ragged, finally snapped out of her stupor. Rising to her feet, fists trembling with a mix of anger and desperation, she shouted after Homura.

“You’re seriously saying this now? After everything we’ve been through?” Kyoko’s voice cracked with raw emotion. “How can you be so calm—so... uncaring—at a time like this?!”

Homura didn’t stop. Her footsteps echoed quietly as she continued walking.

“Is this some kind of cruel game to you?” Kyoko’s voice rose, filled with hurt and fury. “Do you enjoy watching us break? How do you even know all this? What are you? **How can you call yourself human?**”

For the first time, Homura paused. Her back was still turned, but slowly, deliberately, she tilted her head just enough to answer.

Kyoko froze—her breath caught in her throat—when their eyes met. **Homura’s gaze was utterly inhuman**, cold and void of any flicker of emotion, as if she were something not quite alive.

Her voice was ice scraping across stone, each word cutting through the heavy silence.

“You’re right. I don’t call myself human. And neither should you.”

Without another glance, Homura turned away and walked on.

Mami’s hand flew to her mouth, her eyes wide with shock, her heart pounding fiercely in her chest.

Kyoko’s lips parted, as if she wanted to shout back, to challenge Homura’s cold words. But no sound came.

Deep down, she knew—everything Homura had said was true. The harsh reality they all faced was undeniable.

Her shoulders sagged, and her eyes fell to the ground. The fire that once burned fiercely within her now flickered weakly, overshadowed by a crushing weight of defeat.

Her fist clenched tightly at her side, trembling—not with anger, but with a painful, silent resignation.

But just as Homura passed out of the frame, the projection lingered—capturing a subtle, telling detail the others in that moment—Madoka, Sayaka, Kyoko—might’ve missed.

Her hands.

Fists clenched at her sides. Tight. Trembling.

It was brief, but unmistakable.

Mami leaned forward slightly, her breath catching.

“She’s not cold,” she whispered, voice wavering. “She’s not emotionless. She’s... hurting.”

Across from her, Kasumi remained silent, eyes fixed on the empty space where Homura had just vanished. Her expression was unreadable, shadowed by thought.

Lunaria sat still as well, but her gaze was heavy with quiet sorrow. She’d seen enough pain to recognize its shape—no matter how carefully it was hidden.

The projection remained still for a moment, quiet as the echo of Homura’s footsteps faded into the distance.

Sayaka slowly rose to her knees, one hand gripping the edge of the railing as she steadied herself. Her breath came in ragged, shallow pulls. The shock hadn’t fully worn off—her body moved, but her thoughts lagged behind, like they couldn’t keep up with the truth now etched into her soul.

"A shell," she repeated in her mind.

"My body... it’s not even me. I’m not even... human anymore."

She looked down at her hands, flexing her fingers. They moved—she could feel them. But now, that movement felt false. Disconnected. Hollow.

"What have I done...?"

Kyoko stood nearby, shoulders slumped, fists trembling at her sides. She couldn’t meet Sayaka’s eyes—not after what they’d just said to each other. Not after nearly tearing each other apart, only to realize they were both puppets dancing at the end of a contract they barely understood.

"You’re right. I don’t call myself human."

Homura’s words rang in her ears, louder than anything else.

Kyoko bit the inside of her cheek, hard, forcing the sting to keep her grounded. She had wanted to scream something back at Homura—anything. But what could she say, when everything the girl said was **true**?

"We’re just... ghosts in borrowed bodies."

The thought made her stomach twist. **"And I almost killed Sayaka over pride."**

She dropped her gaze to the asphalt beneath her boots, shame wrapping around her like a chain.

Madoka, meanwhile, stood between them both—frozen not by shock, but by a storm of thoughts she couldn't untangle. Her eyes remained on the place where Homura had vanished with Sayaka's soul gem. Where she'd jumped—without hesitation—just to retrieve it.

Madoka's hand still hung in the air where she had thrown it, as if her mind hadn't caught up with her body yet.

She remembered what she had said to Homura the day before. Angry, hurt words—accusing her of giving up, of being heartless, of abandoning Sayaka.

But she didn't.

She jumped. She saved her.

Madoka's fingers curled into a fist.

"Why...? Why did she tell me to give up on Sayaka if she never did? What did she really mean?"

There was more to Homura—**so much more.**

A quiet dread settled in Madoka's chest. If Sayaka's soul being displaced made her body go limp... then what was **beyond** that?

"What could be worse than being a lifeless shell? Who are you, Homura? What do you know... and why are you hiding it from us...?"

She didn't know the answer—but as Homura's figure faded into the shadows, the weight of the question pressed in on her. Heavy. Silent. Unspoken.

In the arena, Mami sat frozen, her hands gripping her knees so tightly her knuckles turned white. Her heart ached.

Her friends weren't just drifting.

They were unraveling.

Breaking.

And only one of them—**Homura**—truly understood why.

The projection shimmered softly... then dimmed.

Silence lingered in the arena. A heavy silence, steeped in thought, in grief, in questions left unanswered.

Mami slowly exhaled, her voice quiet but steady. "That's... a lot to take in."

She looked down at her hands, clenched in her lap. “If this keeps up, I wouldn’t be surprised if Sayaka or Kyoko... started spiraling. The weight’s too much. The truth of it all, the helplessness.”

Her eyes drifted to the petals around them, then toward the quiet night sky beyond the arena walls.

“Kyoko’s stronger than she lets on. She’s suffered more than most—more than me. But Sayaka...” Her voice faltered. “Sayaka still sees the world in ideals. And when that world starts to crumble...” Her words hung like dew on a blade of grass. “I think she’ll be the first to break.”

Lunaria didn’t speak at first. She simply placed a hand gently over Mami’s once more, steady and calm. Kasumi looked down, her expression serious.

Mami turned toward them. “Thank you for showing me this. Really. I needed to see it. This—this is the motivation I needed to keep going. The technique you’re teaching me... this dis-connect, this way to siphon out despair, it might be the only thing that can help them. And now I understand how urgent this really is.”

Lunaria gave a slow, approving nod, her voice quiet but resolute. “That urgency... that’s the spark that turns learning into purpose. I’m glad you see it.”

Kasumi grinned and leaned forward, arms resting on her knees. “And it’s the best kind of motivation—the kind born from love. You’re not doing this to chase power. You’re doing this to protect people you care about. That’s the strength that *won’t* betray you.”

Mami met their eyes and gave a small, heartfelt smile. “Exactly. I don’t want another promise I can’t keep. This time, I’ll reach them with something I understand. Something real.”

Kasumi let out a breath and stood, clapping her hands once to break the mood. “Alright, enough of that for tonight! If we keep going, we’re all gonna cry.”

Mami blinked, then gave a soft laugh.

“Come on,” Kasumi continued, beckoning them up with a grin. “Let’s do something fun before bed. I know *just* the place.”

Chapter 8: Having Fun

The glade opened up before them again—not far from where Mami had meditated earlier that day, where she had seen Lunaria playing harp and flute under the stars. The gentle sound of water lapping against the shore reached their ears. The lake stretched out, still and luminous, reflecting the moonlight like a glass canvas dotted with stardust. The mountains on the far side loomed like sleeping guardians beneath the sky.

Mami’s breath caught again, just like the first time.

Kasumi gestured toward the lake. “Isn’t it gorgeous? Let’s sail out a bit. The view’s even better from the water.”

“Do we have a boat?” Mami asked, glancing around.

“Working on it,” Lunaria said gently, stepping toward the shore.

She knelt, placed a hand on the grass, and closed her eyes. Light gathered around her fingertips—not brilliant, but soft, alive. Wooden beams rose from the earth, weaving together in elegant, spiraling patterns. In moments, a small boat formed at the water’s edge. No sail, no oars—but sleek and balanced.

Mami’s eyes widened. “You used... connect?”

Lunaria nodded with a small smile. “The trees gave me some of their essence earlier. I’m borrowing it now to shape the boat. When we’re done, I’ll return it. Nothing wasted.”

“So it’s not like food,” Mami murmured. “You’re not consuming it. You’re reshaping it.”

“Exactly,” Lunaria replied. “Energy and essence are part of the same cycle. The more we understand it, the more possibilities we can create.”

Mami was quietly stunned. “There really are so many ways to use this...”

Kasumi gave her a playful nudge. “And I *really* want to see what your creative brain comes up with once you get the hang of it. I bet you’ll blow us away.”

Mami smiled again, warm and sincere.

The three girls stepped into the boat together, Lunaria guiding them with a hand motion. The vessel glided away from the shore smoothly, as if drawn by invisible threads across the starlit lake.

Moonlight danced on the surface around them. The air was cool, serene, and filled with quiet promise.

And for a while, the weight of truth gave way to the gentleness of peace.

The boat glided softly across the mirrored surface of the lake, its movement guided not by wind or oars, but by quiet intention—Lunaria’s magic gently shaping the current like a lullaby.

No ripples beyond what they made themselves.

No sound but the gentle creak of wood and the soft whisper of water brushing against the hull.

Above them, the stars shimmered in scattered constellations, mirrored flawlessly in the lake’s stillness below. In places, the water was so smooth and dark it became a second sky—seamless, boundless. It was hard to tell where the heavens ended and the earth began.

Kasumi leaned forward at the bow of the boat, golden eyes wide and shining. “Ooh, look—look there!” she gasped, crouching like a child seeing magic for the first time.

Beneath the boat, a small school of glowing fish swam just below the surface, trailing ribbons of bioluminescence like drifting stardust.

Drawn to her radiant, untamed energy, the lake's aquatic life began to gather.

Fish leapt in playful arcs alongside the boat, emitting bubbly, high-pitched chirps. Some puffed out harmless jets of water in her direction, like teasing friends. One particularly cheeky fish launched a stream of water that splashed her squarely in the face.

"Ack—!" Kasumi yelped, stumbling backward, water dripping down her cheek. She blinked, soaked and startled, then burst into laughter. "Oh, come on! I'm not bait!"

Above, a small flock of lake birds fluttered down from the trees, chirping as they landed on the edge of the boat—one perching on her shoulder, another making itself comfortable on her head like it belonged there.

"Oh no—now it's birds?! You guys are conspiring!" Kasumi cried, batting at them with exaggerated betrayal. One of them tried to nibble on a loose strand of her hair. "Lunaria, help! Mami, *defend me!*"

"They're not conspiring," Lunaria replied serenely, not even turning. "You're like a lightning rod for life, Kasumi. They're drawn to your charisma and playfulness."

Kasumi pouted dramatically, arms crossed. "Yeah, yeah. Just don't let them throw me overboard. No—hey—stop that! That was a *joke*, do not take me literally!" She scurried away from a particularly enthusiastic fish and birds, flailing in mock panic. "*Help me, Lunaria!*"

"I would actually like to see that," Lunaria said, lips curved in a rare teasing smirk as she watched the chaos unfold with calm amusement.

Kasumi narrowed her eyes. "I *knew* you were secretly chaotic."

Lunaria merely smiled, eyes drifting back to the lake's shimmering surface.

She sat near the front of the boat, her long indigo hair catching the moonlight like strands of silk. Her posture was graceful, at ease, her gaze thoughtful. The lake beneath reflected the stars with such perfect clarity, it felt as if the boat were floating through the night sky itself.

She extended a hand over the side, her fingers brushing through the cool surface. A luminous fish broke the water nearby and hovered for a moment. Without hesitation, Lunaria reached out and gently stroked its back. The fish lingered in her palm, then slipped silently back beneath the surface.

A small, soft-winged bird hopped beside her on the boat's edge, cooing quietly. Lunaria turned her hand and let it climb into her palm. She stroked its head with quiet grace, the bird closing its eyes in complete comfort.

Mami sat between them, her laughter soft and light as she watched Kasumi's clumsy antics and the playful, wordless bond that danced between her and Lunaria.

Watching Kasumi scramble from one end of the boat to the other, trying to dodge an especially mischievous fish determined to splash her, Mami felt something warm rise in her chest—a smile that wasn't forced, but real. Gentle. Quiet.

A smile that never happened back when she was “alive” as a magical girl.

It was peaceful—not just in sound, but in spirit.

A peace that went deeper than silence.

A peace that filled the cracks in her heart.

A peace that was ... fun.

She leaned back slightly, tilting her head toward the heavens. Her gaze traced the constellations above, then drifted to their reflections below—the sky and lake so perfectly mirrored, they seemed to wrap around the boat like a dream. The outline of the distant mountains loomed dark and soft against the starlight, and the moon's reflection shimmered on the water like a silver guardian watching over them.

A thought stirred deep inside her.

If only they could all be here...

Madoka. Sayaka. Kyoko.

Yachiyo. Mifuyu.

Iroha, Tsuruno, Sana, Felicia...

Every magical girl—whether from Mitakihara or Kamihama.

They deserve this too.

She let her eyes close for a moment, breathing in the scent of pine and water, letting the moment soak into her soul. Even after everything—even the worst of it—they still had *this*.

Moments like this.

Beauty like this.

Peace like this.

Madoka would love it here, Mami thought. She'd sit quietly at first, in awe—and then rush to the edge of the boat to see the fish up close.

Sayaka would complain it was too quiet, too slow... but before long, she'd be hanging off the side, laughing and splashing like a child.

Kyoko would act like it was boring—like she didn't care—but she'd be watching everything with that look in her eyes. That soft, faraway look she tried to hide.

And then there was Homura.

Mami's thoughts faltered, the image of Homura's icy, distant expression flashing in her mind—the cold eyes that seemed almost inhuman, the way she kept others at arm's length.

But Mami had seen something else too in the projections—small glimpses of something softer, more fragile, buried beneath that frozen exterior. The subtle trembling of clenched fists... the quiet, almost imperceptible grimaces that crossed Homura's face in moments of pain—moments the others never noticed.

They weren't the reactions of someone uncaring. They were the cracks in a carefully built wall, signs of someone trying so hard not to fall apart.

The quiet hurt hidden behind the mask.

She wondered, quietly, what Homura might be like if the weight she carried were lifted even for a moment—if the ice around her heart could melt to reveal the warmth and light Mami suspected was still there.

What would a more human Homura look like?

Would she laugh like Kasumi, or smile like Madoka?

Would she find peace here, on a calm lake under the stars?

Mami didn't know the answers. But she hoped, somehow, that one day Homura could find that softer, warmer version of herself—one that could rest, and heal, and be free.

And the others from Kamihama...

Yachiyo and Mifuyu would stand tall, quiet, regal—watching, protecting.

Iroha would try to befriend every bird and fish that came near.

Tsuruno would name them all like honored guests.

Sana would sit silently with a gentle smile, her presence as soothing as the water itself.

Felicia... she'd be bouncing around the boat trying to catch fish with her hands.

Mami smiled, wistfully and whole.

All of them should be here.

The night air brushed gently against her skin, cool and sweet. The lake whispered beneath them, and somewhere in the far-off hills, a loon called—its song echoing like a lullaby from another world.

And in her heart, beneath all the sorrow and truth, Mami held onto one small, steady hope:

Maybe... just maybe...

One day, she could bring them here.

Not just in memory.

But in person.

Mami's heart was still full from her thoughts, lingering in that quiet dream of sharing this moment with everyone she cared about—when Kasumi's voice shattered the calm like a rock tossed into still water.

"Okay, I've officially had enough of the animal uprising!" Kasumi announced with theatrical flair, flailing a bit as another bird pecked playfully at her sleeve. "They're trying to throw me overboard! It's mutiny!"

She turned to Lunaria, hands on her hips in exaggerated defiance. "Captain Lunaria, I respectfully request command of the vessel! I need to reclaim my honor before I get pecked into submission!"

Lunaria's lips curved into a knowing smile. "The boat is yours," she said gently, tone amused. She didn't need to ask what Kasumi would do. She already knew.

Mami blinked, her smile faltering slightly. "Um... should I be concerned?" she asked aloud, though mostly to herself. She had known Kasumi only a short while, but the patterns were becoming clear. Chaos followed her like a devoted pet.

Kasumi clapped her hands together, eyes gleaming with the unholy joy of impending speed. "All right, lake dwellers! You think you're fast? You think you've got fins and feathers and flair? Then I—
Kasumi the Unyielding, Queen of Chaos, Ruler of Ridiculous Speeds—issue you a challenge!"

She struck a dramatic pose, one foot perched on the boat's edge. "Prepare yourselves for... Maximum! Overdrive!"

The boat lurched—then rocketed forward like it had been launched from a magical slingshot. Water sprayed out behind them in glittering arcs. The stars above became streaks of light, and the lake blurred into lines.

Lunaria, still seated calmly near the front, chuckled gently, her indigo hair streaming behind her like a river of silk. She looked entirely unbothered, serene even, as if they were still gliding slowly under moonlight.

Mami, however, was immediately in semi-panic mode. "K-Kasumi?! What are you doing?! Is this safe?!" She barely managed to wrap her golden ribbons around the boat in time to brace herself. Despite her alarm, a burst of laughter escaped her lips—it was ridiculous, reckless, and undeniably Kasumi.

Kasumi's face was wind-whipped and wild with joy, her grin stretching ear to ear. "Safe? What's that?! This is freedom!! Woo-hooooooooo!"

Behind them, the fish and birds they'd left behind began making comical, high-pitched sounds—as if accepting the challenge. Some birds flapped harder, some fish zipped forward in energetic bursts, all chasing after the rogue boat with determined (if hopeless) energy.

"Ha! Eat my wake, aquatic squad! I reign supreme!" Kasumi whooped, throwing a triumphant fist in the air as she glanced back at their fading silhouettes.

Just as Kasumi was basking in her hard-won "victory," Mami suddenly shouted, her voice laced with panic.

"Kasumi! Look ahead—what is that?!"

Kasumi turned, still grinning—only for her eyes to widen in horror.

Several massive tail fins had emerged from the water ahead, sleek and shimmering like blades of silver moonlight. They moved in eerie unison, forming a glistening arc that rose from the lake like a ramp. It sparkled with bioluminescent scales, curving upward in perfect trajectory—aimed directly into the sky.

"Ack—It's a trap!" Kasumi screamed. "We've been bamboozled!"

"Kasumi, turn us! *Slow down!*" Mami shrieked, clinging to her ribbons, wind blasting her face as she gritted her teeth.

"I *can't*!" Kasumi yelled back. "The ramp—it's too perfect! THEY CHECKMATED ME!"

Behind her, the birds let out what sounded like teasing chirps. The fish leapt in gleeful arcs, clearly in on the aquatic conspiracy.

Lunaria sat serenely, eyes half-lidded, watching the rapidly approaching ramp with the quiet amusement of someone watching fate unfold in precisely the way she expected. "Oh dear," she said, softly chuckling. "They really did."

The boat hit the base of the ramp and launched.

Not just jumped. *Launched*.

It soared into the air like a star shooting free of gravity's grip, cutting a glorious arc against the moonlit sky. The water fell away beneath them in shimmering sheets. Time seemed to slow.

Mami screamed again, this time much louder. "*WHYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYY—!*" She clung to the boat with every magical ribbon she could conjure, her pigtails flailing like golden streamers in the wind.

Lunaria calmly hovered just above the wooden deck, her body enveloped in a subtle shimmer of magic. Her long indigo hair streamed behind her like silk in slow motion. She turned her head slightly, looking down at the lake from their great height.

"Such a lovely view from up here," she mused.

Once Mami managed to get her ribbons wrapped tightly around the boat's interior—and had stopped screaming quite as loudly—she did a frantic headcount.

"...Wait—where's Kasumi?!"

For a brief second, the boat hung suspended in the air. Then—

"*WAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHH!!*"

The scream came from behind and above.

Mami and Lunaria turned in unison, just in time to see Kasumi flipping helplessly through the air, limbs flailing in a full aerial spiral.

She hit the water with an enormous *SPLAAAASH!* that sent up a fountain of lake water higher than the boat itself.

Mami winced. “Oof... that had to hurt.”

She couldn’t help but flash back—back to the arena where she first met Kasumi, the jump from the flower pods with absolutely no landing plan. Or the Kamihama talent show, where Kasumi rode a toddler-sized bicycle onto the stage while playing terrible recorder music dressed in a clown outfit... and crashed off it as she made her way to her mic.

Mami looked toward Lunaria.

They both burst out laughing.

But Mami’s laughter cut short as she realized something: the boat was still up in the air.

Her smile vanished.

“Oh no. No no no—WE’RE NEXT!”

She screamed again, bracing herself. “I’m not ready for a Kasumi-style impact!”

She threw her arms around the side of the boat and shut her eyes, preparing for splashdown doom.

But just as the boat began to descend, Lunaria raised her hand. Her magic flowed forward like silk unraveling from a spool, wrapping gently around the vessel. The speed slowed. The descent softened.

With a faint *fwoosh* of displaced air, the boat glided back down and touched the surface of the lake with a gentle kiss.

Mami slowly opened her eyes.

“...We’re alive?”

Lunaria offered a small smile. “I figured one impact was enough for tonight.”

Mami exhaled hard, still catching her breath. “I haven’t had a non-life-or-death adrenaline rush like that since—” she paused, eyebrows raised, “—honestly, I can’t remember. That one time Kyoko dragged me to an amusement park and ‘forced’ me to go on the Tower of Terror.”

Lunaria chuckled. “You’ll find that’s normal when Kasumi is involved.”

After a few long moments of silence, a dripping voice echoed across the water.

“Owowowowow... my everything hurts...”

Kasumi surfaced, coughing and flailing slightly as she tried to tread water with what dignity she had left. “Okay... update... head spinning... ribs questioning their life choices... and my butt is filing a complaint.”

The massive aquatic creatures circled her, their tails swishing lazily through the water as they made low, musical sounds—like laughter in another language.

A few birds swooped in, chirping in delight as they hovered above her. The fish from before encircled Kasumi, leaping in playful arcs around her.

Kasumi groaned dramatically, then burst into laughter, arms still flailing as one of the fish nudged her playfully from below. “Alright, alright! I surrender! I got launched like a firework and dunked like a cookie—you win!”

The lake creatures chirped and trilled in what could only be described as smug aquatic delight. A few fish circled her, splashing gently, while the birds swooped low to ruffle her hair with their wings before darting off again. The large aquatic animals swam close, lifting her slightly on a gentle wave as if parading their trophy.

Kasumi floated on her back, kicking gently, giggling like a child surrounded by old friends. “You guys are brutal... I like it. Just don’t make this a weekly thing, okay?”

She spent a little while longer in the water with them, letting them tug her around in circles, gliding over the surface like an oversized water toy. A fish popped up to nudge her cheek. A bird landed briefly on her stomach before fluttering away, letting out a victorious little chirp.

Eventually, Kasumi sighed contentedly, lifting one hand in the air. “Alright. Fun’s over. The clown has to go home. Curtain call’s done.”

The animals let out soft, farewell sounds—chittering and chirping in chorus, splashing the water like they were clapping.

Kasumi smiled fondly at them, brushing water from her face. “You’re the best, you know that? Tell your friends. You just dunked the Queen of Chaos herself.”

With a final wave, she began swimming back toward the boat, still sluggish from the impact but clearly in good spirits. “Get ready to catch me, ladies. I’m pretty sure my everything still hurts.”

Mami leaned over the side with a ribbon already snaking down. “Honestly, it’s a miracle you’re not in pieces.”

Kasumi grabbed the ribbon and let it pull her closer. “I’m in emotional pieces. **Emotional damage!**,” she groaned theatrically, “but that’s just Tuesdays.”

Lunaria offered a hand as Kasumi hauled herself back aboard, soaked and flopping onto the deck like a fish just reeled in. Her hair was matted to her face, her clothes clinging to her like a second skin, and her grin was wide enough to reach the moon.

“Ow. My spleen,” she muttered, flopping flat on her back. “I might’ve invented a new kind of pain.”

Mami looked down at her, half-concerned, half-amused. “Did your spleen even *do* anything in this situation?”

“It was *there*, okay? It *felt things*.”

The boat returned to its soft, drifting pace as Lunaria released the last of her stabilizing magic. The lake shimmered calmly once again, the chaos of seconds ago fading like ripples into the night.

Kasumi groaned theatrically and flopped onto her back with a wet squelch. “I feel like a mop that got used to clean a volcano.”

Mami sat across from her, one hand on her chest as she tried to steady her breath. “You nearly gave me a heart attack... twice.”

“Only twice? I must be losing my edge.”

Lunaria chuckled, gently brushing her damp hair behind her ear. “Your edge is very much intact. Perhaps *too* intact.”

The trio sat in silence for a few moments, letting the adrenaline fade into the background hum of the lake’s gentle waves. The stars above resumed their quiet twinkle, and the distant shore remained a dark silhouette beneath the moon’s glow.

Kasumi sat up slowly, wringing water out of her sleeves. “Alright. I am officially defeated. The lake wins. The fish win. The birds win. I admit my humiliating loss to the entire aquatic-animal kingdom.”

From somewhere in the distance, a faint *glub-glub-chirp* answered her declaration—as if the creatures were acknowledging their victory with a chorus of smug celebration.

Kasumi grinned and waved an arm in the air. “Yeah, yeah, rub it in!”

She turned back toward the boat, sighing contentedly as she slumped into her seat. “Still worth it. Ten outta ten. Would absolutely launch myself into the stratosphere again.”

Mami arched an eyebrow. “Why does that *not* make me feel better?”

“Because you’re still sane,” Kasumi replied with a wink.

Lunaria tilted her head. “Or perhaps she’s just not used to chaos as a love language.”

Mami laughed softly at that, then leaned back, allowing herself to finally relax again. The water reflected the stars once more, no longer streaked by speed or splashes—just still, glowing, and gentle.

“...You know,” Mami said quietly, “as ridiculous as all that was... it really *was* beautiful ... and fun...”

Kasumi, still thoroughly soaked and bedraggled, looked up at Mami with a faint, knowing smile. “Well, would you look at that. You’re seeing beauty in other things now.”

Mami blinked, a little caught off guard by the comment.

Lunaria nodded, her voice warm. “Yes. That was beautiful—the way the animals played, the view from so high above the lake... I’m glad you’re starting to enjoy life more, Mami.”

Kasumi’s grin widened, water still dripping from her bangs. “It’s better when you earn it, huh? Chaos first. Beauty after.”

“Or sometimes both at once,” Lunaria added gently, glancing at Kasumi’s soggy yet radiant expression.

Mami looked at them—these strange, wonderful companions—and then out over the moonlit water.

Maybe this wasn’t the kind of peace she’d pictured when she dreamed of quiet moments shared with friends. But it was peace nonetheless. A kind full of laughter, mayhem, and unexpected little wonders.

And in the end... maybe that was even better.

The boat glided slowly back to shore, the once-chaotic ride now a calm drift across the mirrorlike surface of the lake. The moonlight stretched across the water like a pathway, welcoming them home.

As the boat touched the shoreline, Kasumi hopped out—only to land with a wobble. She straightened, struck a triumphant pose... and immediately began flailing her arms as she lost balance for a second time.

“Okay—ow, okay—yep, legs still work! Kind of!” she announced, beginning a series of over-the-top stretches. “Neck, still attached! Shoulders, clicky but functional! Back—ow, okay, questionable. Knees? One’s fine, the other is suing me. But all in all—ten outta ten, would fly again!”

Mami laughed, stepping off the boat with much more grace. “You’re unbelievable,” she said, smiling. “But... that was really fun. Terrifying, reckless... but fun.” She paused, her golden eyes softening. “We should do it again sometime.”

Kasumi beamed. “Really?! Even the fish-launch part?”

“Maybe... a slightly slower version of that part,” Mami added, chuckling.

Lunaria stepped off last, her feet light on the mossy ground. “I’m glad,” she said quietly. “The lake gives its beauty freely—but it gives a little more to those who ask with open hearts.”

With a graceful gesture, she turned to the boat. The wooden vessel shimmered—then slowly broke apart into hundreds of glowing, translucent leaves. They drifted into the air, swirling around the girls like fireflies, before fluttering back toward the trees. Branches rustled faintly as the essence returned to the forest.

Mami blinked, watching in awe. “So that’s what you meant... returning it back to nature.”

She reached out with her hands, trying to touch the **ephemeral leaves** as they drifted away on the breeze. “It’s so pretty...”

Lunaria smiled and nodded. “It was never mine to keep. Just borrowed, for a little while.”

The three of them stood there for a moment, the quiet settling in around them once more—but now, it was a quieter kind of joy. The kind that follows laughter. The kind that lingers after flying too high and laughing too hard.

Then Kasumi stretched again, groaning loudly. “Okay, okay, before I turn into one big bruise—can we go back to the cabin and maybe collapse on some very soft furniture?”

Mami smiled. “Gladly.”

The girls turned and began walking back toward the warm glow of the cabin in the distance, footsteps light, laughter echoing softly through the night air.

Above them, the stars shimmered.

Behind them, the lake lay still once more.

And around them, the forest whispered its approval.

Chapter 9 – Mami’s growth

When they returned to the cabin, the warmth of the wooden walls and the soft glow of the lanterns felt especially inviting after the cool night air of the lake. The calm silence indoors was a stark contrast to the wild ride they’d just endured.

Kasumi groaned dramatically, wobbling toward her room with her arms flailing slightly for balance. “Alright, ladies... I’m officially calling it. If I go to bed now, I *might* still be able to walk tomorrow.” She dragged one leg behind her as if it were limp, then grabbed the doorframe of her room with both hands like she was clinging to life. “Tell my story!” she croaked jokingly.

Mami chuckled behind her hand. “You’re ridiculous.”

Lunaria smiled softly, watching Kasumi’s performance with the patience of someone who had clearly seen this kind of spectacle before.

With a final exaggerated stumble, Kasumi turned and gave them a wink. “Good night, you two. Try not to miss me *too* much.”

She closed the door with a soft click, leaving Mami and Lunaria alone in the quiet of the main room.

They changed into their sleepwear—simple, soft robes provided by the realm’s magic—and settled onto the floor cushions. A small enchanted kettle steamed gently between them, pouring itself into two ceramic cups without either of them lifting a hand. The tea was herbal, warm, and calming—scented faintly with mint and something like lavender.

The silence between them wasn’t awkward. It was peaceful.

Lunaria took a sip, then glanced at Mami with her usual calm curiosity. “Tonight is your third night here,” she said. “How are you feeling... truly?”

Mami blinked, the question taking her slightly off guard. But she didn’t rush her answer. She sat in silence for a moment, cupping her tea in both hands and watching the gentle steam curl toward the ceiling.

“...Honestly?” she said at last, “It’s been so much. So fast. There’s never been a dull moment since I arrived here. Everything’s been packed with... training, lessons, meeting new people, even little adventures like today.”

Her eyes drifted toward the softly glowing window. “It’s exhausting. But it’s also... kind of amazing.”

Lunaria said nothing, only nodding slightly, encouraging her to continue.

“I’ve changed a lot already,” Mami said quietly. “More than I expected. The first day, when I learned the truth about magical girls... and about another way out—that you could escape despair by strengthening your emotional self and by *using* negativity instead of *fighting* it—it felt like something inside me loosened for the first time in years. Like I could breathe again.”

She looked down at her tea, swirling it slowly. “I’ve always thought peace was impossible for someone like me. That the only way to ‘do good’ was to throw myself into danger, to keep saving others until maybe... I’d finally done enough to justify the wish I made.”

Her voice lowered. “To justify surviving.”

Lunaria didn’t interrupt.

“But today,” Mami continued, “I learned something else. I learned about magic’s connection to everything—nature, emotions, the people we care about. I saw beauty in the world again... not just in the scenery, but in the small things. The way the water shimmered. The animals playing. The wind moving through the trees.”

She smiled, almost shyly. “I saw beauty in *my own life*, too. For the first time since becoming a magical girl.”

She took a slow sip of tea, her eyes a little misty.

“And that moment earlier, when I made that tiny leaf from the herbs... it was the first time I felt genuinely proud of something I created. Not because it was flashy or powerful, but because it felt like *me*. Not Mami the fighter. Not Mami the survivor. Just... me.”

Lunaria’s gaze was warm, understanding.

“Back when I first became a magical girl,” Mami went on, “I tried so hard to be good, to do good, but it always felt like a responsibility—like I *had* to keep going to deserve the life I was given. I never really felt pride in it. I just felt... obligation. Pressure.”

She laughed softly. “Even in my free time, I’d try hobbies—cooking, reading, tea ceremonies—but it always felt like I was just filling the time. Nothing truly *moved* me.”

Her smile deepened, gentler now. “But today... that boat ride. That was the first time in years I felt joy. Real, childish, ridiculous joy. I didn’t have to save anyone. I didn’t have to prove anything. I was just... living. Laughing. *Enjoying it.*”

She looked over at Lunaria. “It felt like something I’ve been searching for since the beginning.”

Lunaria nodded. “Then you’re on the right path.”

A silence settled over them again, not heavy, but thoughtful. Mami leaned back slightly on her cushion, tea still warm in her hands.

“I’m not sure where this path will lead,” she said. “But... for the first time, I’m not afraid of that.”

Lunaria’s voice was soft. “That is enough.”

They sat there in the quiet hum of the cabin, the night pressing gently against the windows. Somewhere in the distance, the last call of a loon echoed over the lake.

Mami closed her eyes for a moment, breathing it all in.

She had come here with so much doubt. So much weight.

And now, maybe—for the first time in a very long time—she was starting to let it go.

Mami’s gaze lingered on her tea, watching the faint ripples fade into stillness. Her voice dropped, soft with thought.

“...The girls I saw in the projections today... my friends. The ones from Mitakihara... and the girls from Kamihama too. They all went through so much today.”

She paused, organizing the storm of memory in her mind.

“The Kamihama girls... they found out everything. About how our souls were torn from our bodies and placed into soul gems—that we’re not really alive in the way we thought we were. And worse...” Her voice quieted further. “That magical girls become witches if they fall into despair. They saw it all—through Mifuyu and Yachiyo’s memories.”

Her fingers curled slightly around the teacup. “I wish I could have prepared them more. Helped soften it somehow. But maybe that’s not how healing works.”

She looked over to Lunaria, searching her face.

“My friends from Mitakihara... they only learned the first truth today. About the soul gems. They still haven’t learned what happens when despair overwhelms us. I think... I think that moment is coming soon. I just hope I can finish learning the simplified form of Dis-Connect in time. If I can, maybe I’ll be able to help them when they need it most.”

A flicker of concern passed through her expression—especially as her thoughts turned to Homura.

“...And then there’s Homura. The icy enigma.” A tired smile curved her lips. “She tries so hard to act like she doesn’t care. But today... today she revealed just a little more of herself. She saved Sayaka, even after telling Madoka to give up on her.”

She shook her head slightly. “There’s something deep inside her... something hurting. I don’t know what it is, but... I want her to find peace too.”

She looked back at Lunaria, earnest and hopeful.

“I want all of them to come here someday,” Mami said quietly. “To learn what I’ve learned. To find the peace, the joy... even the silly fun, like we had on the boat today. I want to see what kind of people they become after they’ve had the chance to heal. Especially Homura, Yachiyo, and Mifuyu...”

Her voice softened even more. “They’ve all been through so much. I think... I think the people they used to be—the parts of them that were warmer, more open, maybe even happier—those parts are still there. Just buried. And maybe, in a place like this... they could come back.”

Lunaria listened in gentle silence, then smiled again—tender and certain.

“They might just get that chance. And maybe sooner than you think.”

Then, with a playful sparkle in her eye, she threw her hand in the air and spoke in a dramatic, teasing tone: “As Kasumi says—‘The more the merrier! Especially when chaos is involved!’”

Mami burst into laughter, surprised but delighted.

Lunaria laughed too, her voice like soft chimes, and for a while the room filled with something light and precious—

The gentle bubbling of laughter, easy, natural, unburdened.

Mami leaned back against the cushions, a hand resting loosely on her teacup.

“...Yeah,” she said with a fond sigh. “Kasumi would say that.”

Outside, the moon hung high over the forest, and the stars blinked down, silent witnesses to a night of peace hard-earned.

Lunaria took the final sip of her tea, then rose gracefully from the cushions. She stretched with slow elegance, her silhouette framed by the soft lamplight—arms overhead, spine arching like a willow in the breeze.

“I think I’ll turn in for the night,” she said with a warm smile. Then, with a playful wink added just for Mami, she added, “May your sleep be peaceful... and full of beauty and fun.”

Mami chuckled, her heart warmed. “Good night, Lunaria.”

Lunaria gave a small bow of farewell before gliding quietly to her room.

Mami remained seated for a little longer, letting the tea's warmth settle through her and the gentle quiet of the cabin wrap around her like a blanket. Then, with a soft sigh, she rose and made her way to her own bed.

She slipped under the covers, the room dim and still, save for the faint rustling of trees outside and the occasional chirp of nocturnal life. Her body relaxed, her breath slowed, and her thoughts began to drift...

And with them came dreams.

In her mind's eye, she saw Sayaka—standing alone in the rain, her soul gem dim and trembling. The moment when despair crept in, when she would fall into witchhood.

But this time, someone arrived.

It was Mami—glowing, composed, her voice calm and strong. She stepped forward and raised her hand.

Dis-connect.

The light enveloped Sayaka before the transformation could take hold. The despair was unraveled, the pain unspooled, and Sayaka collapsed into Mami's arms—still a magical girl, still herself.

The dream shifted. Mami guided Sayaka through a doorway of light, and behind her came Madoka, wide-eyed and hopeful. Kyoko followed, muttering something about being dragged into “another one of Mami's weird tea ceremonies,” but smiling all the same. And last... Homura. Silent, guarded. But present.

Together, Mami led them into the realm. The same lake, the same forest, the same sky blooming with stars. Waiting there were Lunaria and Kasumi—Lunaria serene as ever, and Kasumi already bouncing in place with a grin that spelled imminent chaos.

Mami nearly laughed in her sleep at the image. *Oh no... they're going to get the full experience*, she thought. *Just like I did.*

She could already picture it.

Kasumi would somehow pull out an absurdly oversized welcome banner—probably on fire—and yell something like, “Welcome to Therapy Through Chaos!™” before throwing glitter bombs into the air. Sayaka would duck, scream, then yell back. Kyoko would start chasing Kasumi for nearly blinding her. Madoka would laugh nervously, trying to keep the peace. And Homura would just stand there, deadpan, arms crossed... until Kasumi hugged her out of nowhere and dragged her off to play fishing games with talking frogs.

And Lunaria—ever calm, ever poetic, ever mysterious—would speak in gentle riddles and metaphors that Sayaka would complain she didn't understand, but somehow always follow anyway. Madoka would instantly gravitate to Lunaria's peaceful presence. Kyoko would act like she wasn't listening, but

she'd sit nearby, always facing Lunaria as she spoke. And Homura... Homura might not say a word, but Mami knew she'd be listening, quietly absorbing everything.

They would be confused at first. Annoyed, maybe. Disoriented. But Mami could already see it—how their walls would slowly come down, one by one. How the quiet beauty of the place would reach them, just as it had reached her.

And when it did, she would be there—smiling, guiding, laughing right alongside them.

They'll see, she thought fondly. It's going to be so funny watching them go through it. Terrifying at first... then freeing.

She smiled softly in her sleep, the image of her friends surrounded by chaotic glitter and poetic wisdom etched into her dreams.

The dream shifted again, softer now, like petals drifting on water. Mami found herself watching Homura from afar.

At first, the Homura in Mami's dream remained distant—even in this realm of light and possibility. Her posture was still rigid, her expression unreadable. Though she looked calm, she looked uncomfortable in joy. She lingered quietly by the lake's edge, arms folded, absorbing the new world with only the faintest curiosity.

Then came Kasumi—bursting into the scene like a comet made of laughter.

“Come on, Homura! Loosen up! You're in *my* realm now! Turning frowns upside-down is the rule here!” she chimed, radiant and exuberant, radiating warmth.

Homura looked at Kasumi, eyes still blank, face still stoic... “I'm fine.”

But Kasumi wasn't deterred. She perched right beside Homura, nudging her shoulder lightly. “I just... I know the real you is in there somewhere, ice queen or not. I'm giving you credit.”

Mami watched, heart surging as Homura's expression softened—just a flicker of real warmth in her eyes. *Maybe she's listening*, Mami thought.

Over time Homura began to change. Not because she had to, but because she saw something different here: a way to be whole, to connect, to use her magic not as armor but as healing.

Sayaka laughed, teased her. “Look at you—Miss Icy-No-More is actually... smiling. Who are you?”

Kyoko grinned too, nudging her. “I never thought you could show emotion! Don't worry, we won't let you forget it!”

Homura blinked, confused, but the corners of her lips quivered—but this time, upward.

“Told ya! Even ice queens have a gooey center. The smile looks *great* on you Homura!,” Kasumi added with a wink.

Mami wished she could reach through the dream and hug her. Lunaria was there too, her quiet presence beside Homura like an anchor, a smile bright and forgiving, accepting.

Homura’s voice came, low and shocked. “I thought... I thought I could never melt the ice around my heart—the one I put there to protect everyone... including myself.”

Lunaria just nodded, eyes kind. “You were allowed rest. Allowed to be more.”

In that moment, Homura was fully present in the dream. No distance. No reserve. Just the girl Mami wished for Homura to be.

From then on, Homura joined in: laughter in the forest, cups of tea in the meadow, quiet moments under the stars. She helped Madoka tend a garden. She sparred playfully with Kyoko. She listened to Sayaka’s music.

And with Homura finally free of that frozen shell, the dream showed Mami what true harmony looked like.

All of them—together—not just surviving, but *living*. Joyfully, creatively, in friendship.

Mami’s heart swelled as the dream faded. There, in the echo of starlight and laughter, she held onto the image.

The dream flowed onward. Mami now stood at the center of the forest clearing, surrounded by her friends, their soul gems pulsing gently with stable light. They weren’t fighting—not like before. They were creating.

Sayaka, ever theatrical, shaped her magic into waves of healing music, conducting crescendos of energy with wide, fluid gestures, her sword transformed into a glowing conductor’s baton. Her spells were no longer loud bursts of desperate power, but controlled, sweeping harmonies that soothed the heart and calmed the mind.

Kyoko stood beside her, skeptical at first but grinning wildly now as she shaped her own magic into radiant spears of exotic looking food and fire—somehow both nutritious *and* explosive. She called it "Combat Cooking," and while Mami wasn’t sure it would catch on, the sheer joy in Kyoko’s face was enough.

Madoka’s magic bloomed like gardens. Everywhere she stepped, flowers and vines wove themselves from light and emotion, creating protective barriers that pulsed with warmth. Her magic wasn’t about offense or defense—it was about shielding others, nurturing them. Growing hope from within.

And Homura...

Homura's new magic was time, but not in the way it had been before—not as a weapon, not as a chain. Now, she created small windows of memory—gentle moments of pause and reflection that could be shared with others. A time-shelter, where pain could slow, and healing could begin. She didn't need to manipulate time anymore; she used it to give others the space to understand themselves.

Mami felt something shift inside her—a warmth.

She looked down at her own hands, and in her dream, they were weaving ribbons of golden light into spirals of creation. Her magic had evolved too. No longer just weapons for battle, her ribbons became tools of connection. Threads of thought, feeling, understanding. She could braid them into spells that reflected the inner world of those she fought beside. She called it *Threadweaving*. Magic that bound—not in chains, but in unity.

Lunaria watched over them, always nearby, her presence like the steady breeze that guided sails on an open lake. She whispered when needed, taught when asked, but mostly let them find their way.

And Kasumi, ever the spark of chaos, was somehow everywhere and nowhere at once—popping in mid-lesson with outlandish ideas (some *actually worked* others ending in *complete disaster*), laughing through magical flops, and pushing each of them past their comfort zones without apology. She was unpredictable, unstoppable... and kind.

The two of them were a balance.

And Mami saw now: *They weren't leading them. They were walking beside them.*

Her dream-self smiled as she watched this new world unfold—one where magical girls weren't cursed, weren't doomed, weren't forgotten. But *growing*. Creating. Laughing.

A realm where magic was no longer born from desperation... but from joy.

The dream lingered on that image: golden threads criss-crossing the sky, music echoing through the trees, laughter and magic blending into a single, glowing tapestry.

A true utopia.

The dream shifted again—gentle now, yet vibrant with latent tension.

Mami found herself standing atop a high terrace overlooking Kamihama in the golden light of dawn. Below her, the city sprawled serenely—but the peace didn't stretch to the terrace. There, two sides faced one another with palpable distance between them.

On one side stood **Iroha**, **Tsuruno**, **Sana**, **Felicia**, and **Yachiyo**—girls bound by camaraderie and hardship. Their eyes were weary, their postures guarded. They had fought together, survived together—but the fight had left them raw and uncertain.

Across the divide stood the **Wings of the Magius**—**Mifuyu**, **Kuroe**, and **Mitama**. They looked resolute, even hopeful, their voices gentle as they spoke of salvation through the **APS and doppel system**.

But something felt off. Mami sensed it clearly: their proposed solution was built on trembling foundations—power harnessed from grief they hadn’t learned to understand. It was fire without foresight gleaming in the dark.

Between them hovered an echo of a painful memory—that moment **Kasumi had shown Mami**: Mifuyu extending her invitation to her peers, full of hope. Yachiyo’s expression had held fierce skepticism.

That suspicion simmered still.

Mifuyu stepped forward, trembling with determination. “We only want to save everyone,” she said softly. “This system... it’s our solution.”

Yachiyo’s arms stayed folded, her gaze cold. “It sounds the same,” she replied firmly. “Salvation through power we don’t understand? I’ve heard that song before.”

Before Mami could interject, a soft radiance swelled beside her.

Sayaka. Kyoko. Madoka. Homura.

Her Mitakihara friends had come—as if the dream itself beckoned them to mend this divide.

Sayaka raised her hands wide. “You’ve got the same goal—why are you tearing each other apart?”

Kyoko let out a wry bark of laughter. “Yeah, and you’re doing it in ways that’ll get you hurt—fast.”

Madoka’s voice rang with gentle conviction. “There are other ways. Ways we’ve discovered. We want to share them.”

Mami stepped into the light of reconciliation. “You don’t have to choose between controlling magic through force and despair—or surrendering to it. Magic can be more. It can be balance. Emotional clarity. Connection.”

Her tone was both invitation and promise. She spoke of tears, of acknowledging even the darkest parts of oneself, and of grounding, breathing, and quiet strength—not suppression, but acceptance.

Slowly, their expressions changed.

Mifuyu exhaled, uncertain but curious; Kuroe’s eyes shone with hesitant wonder; Mitama’s smile softened into something honest and frail.

Finally, Yachiyo spoke—arms still folded, skepticism firm in her eyes. “So this is another dream? Another fairytale?”

Homura stood and spoke next, her voice low and unwavering. “It’s not belief—it’s practice. Understanding magic with clarity. Not denying anything about yourself. It’s control of emotion you know and can wield.”

Iroha moved close to Yachiyo, offering a gentle nudge. “There’s no harm in trying. It seems natural. Compassionate. Why not experiment?”

Yachiyo sighed in defeat but acceptance. “All right—fine. I’ll try it. But don’t expect miracles.”

Mifuyu’s voice was soft but earnest. “Teach me too.”

Mami, her two groups united in curiosity, watched as they nodded, thankful and ready.

Kyoko’s infectious grin returned. “Then let’s get started. And first”—she spread her arms wide—“we find the place where we train. A true sanctuary.”

With that, the sky rained forgiveness, and the world changed.

They stepped into the realm, not with defeat, but with cautious hope.

And in the closing image of the dream, Mami saw a vivid tapestry:

Magical girls of all stripes—old friends and newly healed—gathered in harmony. They laughed, they healed, they created. They painted the shoreline, crafted delicate gardens, flew kites through golden rays of light, fluttered through forest trails, brewed comforting tea in laughter, and sailed across mirrored waters.

There were no sorrow distillations. No fractured souls. No fighting for fragments.

Only peace. **A utopia sculpted from understanding, not wishes.**

With that final image in her mind, Mami drifted toward deep sleep.

A single, fervent wish echoed through her heart:

Let this dream become real.

Moonlight washed softly through the windows. Mami slept—dreaming of the healing and hope she hoped to bring to all.